



CITY: Pg 3

Clean air drive:  
No PUC? No fuel



NATION: Pg 5

Kejriwal, Thackeray back  
Mamata on eve of polls



FILM: Pg 10

'Now I really  
value the chill'

CRUCIAL ASSEMBLY POLLS

Over 9 crore voters to reshape political landscapes in Tamil Nadu, West Bengal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA/CHENNAI: Two high-stakes electoral exercises will unfold on April 23, as Tamil Nadu goes to the polls across all constituencies and West Bengal conducts its first phase of voting. Over 5.73 crore voters in Tamil Nadu will decide the fate of 4,023 candidates, while 3.60 crore electors in West Bengal will vote across 152 Assembly segments. Both states are witnessing extensive security deployments, strict enforcement measures, and heightened monitoring to ensure smooth polling amid intense political contests and concerns over inducements and misinformation.

West Bengal's first phase will see voting across 44,376 polling stations, including 41,418 main booths and 2,958 auxiliary units, with an average of 813 voters per station. The electorate includes 1.84 crore men, 1.75 crore women, and 465 transgender voters. A total of 1,478 candidates are in the fray, including 1,311 men and 167 women.



Polling officials carry electoral material including EVM and VVPAT machines as they leave for their respective polling stations from a distribution centre on Wednesday

The phase covers districts across north Bengal and western regions, including Darjeeling, Jalpaiguri, Cooch Behar, Malda, Murshidabad, Jhargram, Purulia, Bankura, Birbhum, and West Burdwan.

Constituencies such as Cooch Behar Dakshin, Karandighi and Itahar have 15 candidates each, while Chandrakona has five contestants. Samsheganj has the smallest electorate at 1.61 lakh, while Daspur has

over 2.96 lakh voters. In West Bengal, the electoral contest is anchored in a fierce battle between the ruling Trinamool Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party, with both sides seeking to consoli-

date their influence across key regions going to the polls in the first phase. The politically significant Nandigram constituency is among the focal points, where Leader of Opposition Suwendu



- » 5.73 crore voters in Tamil Nadu to decide fate of 4,023 candidates
- » West Bengal first phase covers 3.60 crore voters across 152 constituencies
- » Tamil Nadu contest pits DMK-led SPA against AIADMK-led NDA
- » West Bengal voting at 44,376 polling stations with 1,478 candidates contesting
- » 2,407 CAPF companies, 2,100 QRTs deployed in West Bengal
- » 100 per cent webcasting and AI monitoring implemented across Bengal booths

Trump extends US-Iran ceasefire; Iranian forces fire on three ships

Trump signals talks possible within 72 hours

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

WASHINGTON/ISLAM-ABAD: US President Donald Trump extended the ceasefire with Iran indefinitely at the request of Pakistan to give Tehran's leadership more time to prepare a unified proposal to end the war, even as Iranian forces fired on three ships and seized two of them in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday.

Trump's dramatic announcement, welcomed by Pakistan's top leadership, came just hours before the two-week ceasefire was set to expire.

Iran's semi-official Tasnim news agency reported that Tehran has not issued any official statement confirming its agreement to extend the ceasefire. Pakistan had urged an extension of the truce due to uncertainty surrounding the second round of talks. There was still no clarity on the date of the next round of talks.

On Wednesday, The New York Post quoted President Trump as saying that the second round of the US-Iran talks could take place as early as Friday. Such development



A cargo ship sails in the Persian Gulf toward the Strait of Hormuz, on Wednesday

TAKEAWAYS

- » Iran has not officially confirmed agreeing to the ceasefire extension
- » Pakistan sought delay amid uncertainty over second round of talks
- » No confirmed date yet for next round of US-Iran negotiations

» Trump says talks could begin within 36 to 72 hours

» Iran says no decision yet on attending Islamabad talks

» Tehran accuses US of lacking seriousness and good faith in negotiations

was "possible" within the next 36 to 72 hours, the paper reported, quoting Trump.

However, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail

Baqaei said Tehran has not yet decided whether to attend a new round of Pakistani-mediated talks in Islamabad.

Continued on P4

Quick News

BEIJING—DELHI DIRECT FLIGHTS RESUME AFTER NEARLY 6 YEAR

NEW DELHI: Non-stop air links between the capitals of India and China have resumed, with Air China restarting its Delhi-Beijing service on Tuesday after a suspension since 2020.

The airline said on Facebook that flights will operate three times a week on Tuesdays, Fridays and Sundays using Airbus A330-200 and A330-300 aircraft. The resumption restores connectivity disrupted first by the COVID-19 pandemic and later by the Eastern Ladakh military standoff.

Earlier, China Eastern Airlines relaunched direct flights between Kunming and Kolkata on April 18, operating six weekly Boeing 737 services, following the revival of the Shanghai-Delhi route in November 2025.

Indian carrier IndiGo has also expanded operations, introducing daily Kolkata-Shanghai flights on March 29 and resuming routes to Guangzhou.

Continued on P4

EC ISSUES 'STERN NOTICE' TO KHARGE FOR CALLING MODI 'TERRORIST'

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission on Wednesday issued a "stern notice" to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge after taking "serious note" of his remark referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi as a "terrorist", asking him to respond within 24 hours. The development comes a day before polling in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, bringing the controversy into sharp focus ahead of voting.

Kharge made the remark on Tuesday at a press conference in Chennai while criticising the AIADMK's alliance with the BJP. Questioning the ideological position of the regional party, he referred to Modi as a "terrorist" while arguing that the alliance was inconsistent with the legacy of Periyar and C N Annadurai. The comment triggered strong reactions from the BJP, which accused the Congress leader of using inappropriate language.

Continued on P4

India will never bow to any form of terror: PM Modi on Pahalgam attack anniversary

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: On the first anniversary of the Pahalgam terror attack, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday asserted that India will never bow to any form of terror and the heinous designs of terrorists will never succeed.

The Pakistan-based terror group Lashkar-e-Taiba carried out an attack at Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir on this day last year, killing 26 innocent people, mostly tourists from across India. "Remembering the innocent lives lost in the gruesome Pahalgam terror attack on this day last year. They will never be forgotten," Modi said in a post on 'X'.

The Prime Minister said his thoughts are also with the bereaved



The Prime Minister said his thoughts are also with the bereaved families as they cope with this loss.

"As a nation, we stand united in grief and resolve. India will never bow to any form of terror. Continued on P4

Cal HC stays EC's 'blanket order' on 'troublemaker', flags lack of legal basis

SOUMYADIP MULLICK

THE CASE

KOLKATA: Observing that "police observer in the office of Chief Election Officer, West Bengal has erred in issuing blanket direction by treating certain citizens as trouble-makers", the Calcutta High Court on Wednesday stayed the operation of an order by the Election Commission of India (ECI) that had identified a list of around 800 such people ahead of the West Bengal Assembly polls.

The order came on a PIL moved on April 20 by advocate Md. Danish Farooqui, alleging that the ECI had prepared a "secret" list targeting members, workers, office-bearers and elected representatives mainly associated with Trinamool Congress. The petitioner alleged that no specific criminal cases or legal grounds were disclosed

- » The petitioner alleged that no specific criminal cases or legal grounds were disclosed against those named
- » "In our prima facie view, the police observer has erred in issuing blanket direction by treating certain citizens as 'trouble-makers'"
- » TMC MP and former top cop Rajeev Kumar alleged that 500 people in Bengal have been arrested in the past 48 hours on the basis of verbal orders from the police observers

against those named. The petition argued that such pre-emptive arrests would violate fundamental rights under Article 21 and Article 14.

Continued on P4

APPEAL AGAINST 2016 DISCHARGE STILL PENDING

Malegaon blast case: 31 deaths and over 19 years later, HC discharges 4 accused; now no one left on trial

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday discharged four men accused in the 2006 Malegaon serial bomb blasts, bringing to a close the trial against the last remaining accused and leaving the case without anyone facing prosecution for an attack that killed 31 people and injured 312. The court quashed all charges, including those under stringent anti-terror provisions, marking a significant turn in a case that has seen multiple investigations and sharply differing conclusions over nearly two decades.

A division bench of Chief Justice Shree Chandrashekhar



FILE PHOTO

» NIA LATER ALLEGED RIGHT-WING EXTREMIST INVOLVEMENT

and Justice Shyam Chandak allowed appeals filed by Rajendra Chaudhary, Dhan Singh, Manohar Ram Singh Narwaria

and Lokesh Sharma. The four had challenged a 2025 order of a special court that framed charges against them under

provisions of the Indian Penal Code, including murder and criminal conspiracy, as well as the Unlawful Activities (Pre-

CLOSER LOOK

- » Blasts on September 8, 2006 killed 31, injured 312
- » Explosions occurred at mosque premises and Mushawarat Chowk after Friday prayers
- » Case saw probes by ATS, Central Bureau of Investigation, and National Investigation Agency
- » ATS initially blamed nine Muslim men linked to SIMI
- » Those nine were jailed about six years, discharged in 2016

vention) Act. A detailed written order from the High Court was awaited.

With this ruling, the case stands at a dead end in terms of criminal accountability. The four men were the last set of accused in the case, following the discharge of nine Muslim men in 2016. The outcome means that, as of now, no individual is set to stand trial for the coordinated bombings that shook Malegaon nearly 20 years ago.

The blasts took place on September 8, 2006, in the communally sensitive town of Malegaon in Maharashtra's Nashik district. Four bombs exploded around 1.50 pm, shortly after Friday prayers. Continued on P4

RESTLESS GUSTS



A motorcyclist on a hot summer day, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh

The victim, who had completed her engineering from IIT Delhi and was preparing for the UPSC examination, was alone at home when the incident took place



Police officials at the site after a woman, daughter of a senior IRS officer, was found murdered at her residence in southeast Delhi's Amar Colony area

incident took place. Her parents discovered her body after returning from the gym and alerted the police around 9 am through a PCR call to Amar Colony Police Station.

Preliminary findings indicate that the woman was sexually assaulted and then strangled using a mobile phone charging cable. Investigators said the final confir-

mation of sexual assault will depend on the postmortem report. Forensic teams have collected evidence from the scene, and the body has been sent for examination.

Police have arrested the main suspect, Rahul Meena, 19, a former househelp who had worked with the family for around eight months before being dismissed about a month ago over alleged misappropriation of daily purchase bills. Two other individuals, a car cleaner and another domestic worker in the neighbourhood, have also been detained for questioning.

Continued on P4

'Look-Out Circulars not confidential, why not inform accused?': SC pulls up CBI, seeks SOP

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to formulate a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) governing the issuance of Look-Out Circulars (LOCs), raising concerns over the manner in which such alerts are currently used against accused persons.

A bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta examined a case where an accused individual was stopped at an airport due to an LOC, despite having prior permission from a competent court to travel abroad. The judges questioned the agency on how such a situation could arise and whether adequate safeguards were in place.

The case involves Nimesh Navinchandra Shah, who is facing prosecution by both the CBI and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) after a company he joined had its account classified as a Non-Performing Asset. Shah has already been granted bail in the CBI case. Two LOCs were issued against him, one by the CBI and another by a bank. While the LOC against his wife has been set aside, the bank-issued LOC is currently under challenge

Continued on P4

Preventing Pahalgam-like terror attack top priority of Govt  
Omar Abdullah

In today's paper

|                             |    |
|-----------------------------|----|
| CITY                        |    |
| NDMC MARKS EARTH DAY        | 3  |
| NATION                      |    |
| SHAH PREDICTS CONG WIPEOUT  | 5  |
| EDIT                        |    |
| REGULATING DIGITAL SPEECH?  | 7  |
| INTERNATIONAL               |    |
| NEPAL HOME MINISTER RESIGNS | 8  |
| BUSINESS                    |    |
| TEXTILE EXPORTS GROW 2.1%   | 9  |
| SPORT                       |    |
| ROYALS DOWN LSG             | 10 |



AQI IN 'POOR' CATEGORY

# Scorching heat grips Capital as mercury breaches 42 degrees C

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi reeled under scorching heat on Wednesday with the maximum temperature crossing the 42 degrees Celsius mark at some stations, while conditions are set to intensify further with a heatwave forecast from April 24.

According to station-wise data, the highest maximum temperature was recorded at Ridge at 42.1 degrees Celsius, which was 3.7 degrees above normal. Ayanagar followed at 41.4 degrees Celsius (three degrees above normal), while Safdarjung, the city's base station, recorded 40.7 degrees Celsius, three degrees above normal.

Lodi Road logged 40.8 degrees Celsius, 3.8 degrees above normal, and Palam



recorded 40.2 degrees Celsius, 1.6 degrees above normal. The 24-hour change in maximum temperatures ranged between 1.6 degrees and 1.9 degrees across stations.

Minimum temperatures also remained above or near

normal at most places.

Palam recorded the highest minimum at 24.6 degrees Celsius, 1.3 degrees above normal, followed by Ayanagar at 23.5 degrees Celsius, 1.1 degrees above normal.

Ridge recorded 23.4 degrees

KEY POINTS

» Minimum temperatures also remained above or near normal at most places

» Palam recorded the highest min at 24.6 degrees C, 1.3 degrees above normal, followed by Ayanagar at 23.5 degrees C, 1.1 degrees above normal

change in minimum temperatures ranged between 1.1 degrees and 2.4 degrees.

The weather department has forecast mainly clear skies for April 23, with the minimum temperature likely around 24 degrees Celsius and the maximum touching 42 degrees Celsius.

Heatwave conditions are expected to set in from April 24, with temperatures likely to rise further and touch the 43 degrees Celsius mark in the coming days.

Air quality in the city remained in the 'poor' category, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) of 216.

According to CPCB standards, an AQI of 0-50 is considered 'good'; 51-100 'satisfactory'; 101-200 'moderate'; 201-300 'poor'; 301-400 'very poor'; and 401-500 'severe'.

# 22-yr-old UPSC aspirant's killing shocks locality; 'dream cut short'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The killing of a 22-year-old UPSC aspirant, who was known for her quiet, ambitious and studious demeanour, has left residents of her Kailash Hills neighbourhood devastated, mourning the loss of a bright future they envisioned for her.

The daughter of a senior Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officer, was allegedly raped and murdered at her residence in southeast Delhi's upscale Kailash Hills locality, police said.

The IIT Delhi graduate, spoke often of becoming an IAS officer and spent most of her time buried in books, according to neighbours, who said her dream "belonged to everyone".

They remembered her discipline, taciturn persona, and an unwavering belief that she would clear the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) examination in her very first attempt. Greater Kailash MLA Shikha Roy said the victim was a bright and talented young woman with a promising future, and her death is a painful loss for the entire community.

"I have known her personally for several years and have seen her grow up as a sincere, disciplined and exceptionally talented girl. She was brilliant in her studies, had completed engineering from IIT Delhi, and was preparing for the UPSC examination with great determination.

"She was an equally good dancer and other cultural



“When she cleared the IIT entrance examination, everyone here felt proud as if our own daughter had achieved something big

activities, and despite being deeply focused on her studies, she remained humble and connected with people around her," Roy said.

The BJP MLA said the family was in deep shock and not in a condition to speak about the incident. "The mother and father are devastated and are not in a position to say anything right now. The police and forensic teams are investigating the matter, and I hope the accused is identified and arrested at the earliest.

"Whoever has committed such a heinous crime must be given the strictest punishment so that it sends a strong message and justice is ensured," she added.

Hussain, who has lived in the neighbourhood for over a decade, said, "She was the kind of child parents ask their own children to emulate."

"She hardly ever came downstairs; did not waste her time. She was always studying. No social media, no unnecessary distractions -- just books, classes and that one dream of becoming an IAS officer. Even when she spoke, it was always about studies or her plans. She was very sure she would make it," he added.

Hussain said the family had shifted to their current residence around 15 years ago from another apartment nearby, and they were known for their simple and quiet lifestyle.

An elderly neighbour, who claimed to have known her since she was four years old, said her family and the locality proudly watched her grow up.

"I have seen her since she was a little girl running around in the colony. Even then, she was different -- calm, sincere and always focused. Later, when she cleared the IIT entrance examination, everyone here felt proud as if our own daughter had achieved something big," he said.

But her real dream was always UPSC. She was confident she would clear it this year. "And honestly, we all believed she would. Her parents were proud and they were waiting for the day sweets would be distributed for her result," he said.

"This happened in the morning, inside her own house, in a locality people consider safe. If a girl who stayed home and studied all day is not safe, then what are we supposed to tell our daughters?" she said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

# Crime Branch nabs man wanted in 2012 cab driver abduction case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** The Crime Branch of the Delhi Police has arrested a man in connection with a robbery-cum-abduction of a cab driver dating back to 2012, officials said.

The accused, identified as Virkesh alias Birkesh alias Vicky (47), a resident of Pratapgarh in Uttar Pradesh, was the alleged mastermind behind the crime registered at Dwarka South police station on 6 February 2012 under relevant sections of the Indian Penal Code.

The case was filed on the complaint of cab driver Sunil Kumar, who was intercepted by two assailants while on duty. They allegedly overpowered him, robbed him of cash and a mobile phone, abducted him, and later abandoned him



“Birkesh evaded capture and was later declared a proclaimed offender by a court

before fleeing with his vehicle.

While one co-accused was arrested during the initial investigation, Birkesh evaded capture and was later declared a proclaimed offender by a court.

Police said a breakthrough came following sustained efforts and technical surveillance, after inputs suggested his

presence in Chandigarh. Acting on the lead, a team under ACP Satendra Mohan analysed old contacts and tracked a suspicious mobile number, helping narrow down his location.

He was eventually traced to Sector 26 in Chandigarh, where he had been living under a false identity and working as a gas cylinder supplier to avoid detection. He was apprehended after careful planning.

During interrogation, Birkesh admitted to frequently changing locations across Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Chandigarh, switching mobile numbers and residences to evade arrest. Police records show he is involved in at least 13 criminal cases, including robbery, burglary, theft, and offences under the Arms Act and Explosive Substances Act.

# Woman falls to death from 29<sup>th</sup> floor in Gzb

DIPIKA KIROLA

**GHAZIABAD:** A woman died after falling from the 29th floor of a high-rise residential society in Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, in the early hours of Wednesday, police said.

The incident occurred at the TNT Tower Society on Pushpa Road, opposite Vivekanand School.

According to officials, the woman had been staying with her daughter, Bhavna, who lives on the 29th floor. She had arrived at her daughter's home two days before the incident.

Around 3 am on Wednesday, her body was found within the society premises. Eyewitnesses said she first struck a parked car before falling to the ground.

Police reached the spot

after being alerted by residents and took custody of the body, which has been sent for postmortem.

Preliminary investigation suggests it may be a case of suicide.

ACP Indirapuram Abhishek Srivastava said the woman had been under mental stress following her husband's death. "All angles are being examined.

Further action will be taken based on the postmortem report and statements from family members," he said.

Residents said the impact caused severe injuries. The builder's team later arrived to clean the area.

Police said the investigation is ongoing to determine the exact circumstances surrounding the incident.

# Anti-drug awareness programme held at east Delhi school

**NEW DELHI:** An awareness programme under the 'Drug Free Delhi Campaign' was organised by the Anti-Narcotics Task Force of the Crime Branch at a government school in east Delhi, with around 250 students participating, officials said. Held at Rajkiya Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya, Trilokpuri, students were sensitised about the ill effects of drug abuse and its impact on health, families and society. The session focused on prevention, early identification and responsible choices.

MPOST

# Wanted murder convict linked to gangs injured, held after gunfight

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** A wanted criminal linked to the Tillu Tajpuri and Kaushal Chaudhary gangs was arrested by the Special Cell of the Delhi Police after a brief exchange of fire in Rohini, officials said.

The accused, Robin alias Babloo alias Rohit alias Ram alias Ramraj (40), a resident of Sonapat, Haryana, is a parole jumper, proclaimed offender, and life convict in two murder cases.

Police recovered an illegal pis-

tol with three live cartridges and a motorcycle from him.

Acting on a tip-off, a Special Cell team laid a trap near Barwala Chowk in Rohini Sector 36 on April 21.

When asked to surrender, he allegedly opened fire, and was injured in retaliatory firing before being taken to hospital.

He had jumped parole in 2025 and was declared a proclaimed offender in 2026.

He also has convictions under the Arms and Explosive Substances Acts and was allegedly planning gang-related attacks.

# DMRC & ICAR-IARI sign MoU for pilot horticulture initiative



**NEW DELHI:** In a step towards strengthening sustainable urban infrastructure, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the ICAR-Indian Agricultural Research Institute (ICAR-IARI) to launch a pilot horticulture initiative across select metro locations.

The MoU was signed on Tuesday in the presence of Director ICAR-IARI Dr. CH. Srinivasa Rao and Director (Infrastructure), DMRC Manoj Singhal, along with senior officials from both organisations.

The pilot project aims to enhance green cover and improve aesthetics at selected

sites, including central verges, areas beneath station structures, and other suitable spaces along metro corridors. Officials said the collaboration would focus on utilising underused urban spaces to create environmentally sustainable landscapes.

Under the agreement, ICAR-IARI will provide technical expertise on selecting plant species suitable for harsh urban conditions, including low-light environments and areas with minimal water availability. It will also guide maintenance practices and conduct periodic evaluations during the pilot phase.

"Under the MoU, ICAR-IARI will provide technical guidance on the selection of plant species suitable for harsh and low-light conditions, having low watering requirements, along with suitable maintenance practices and periodic evaluation during the pilot phase," officials said.

MPOST

# INDIAN CEO MANDATORY FOR GREENFIELD AIRPORTS

# Home Ministry blocks foreign CEOs for airports, Jewar Airport launch hit

DIPIKA KIROLA

**NOIDA:** The Union home ministry has rejected a proposal to amend rules that would have allowed a foreign national to serve as chief executive of a greenfield airport, a decision that directly affects the upcoming Noida International Airport at Jewar, officials familiar with the matter said.

Current regulations mandate that the CEO of a greenfield airport in India must be an Indian citizen, primarily on aviation security grounds. A request to relax this rule was sent by the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), the aviation security regulator under the civil aviation ministry, but was declined. "The home ministry is not in favour of allowing expatriates to head greenfield airports," an official said.

The decision narrows options for the Noida International Airport, which is being developed and will be oper-



ated by Yamuna International Airport Pvt Ltd, a subsidiary of Switzerland-based Zurich Airport International AG. The airport's current CEO, Christoph Schnellmann, is a Swiss national. In the worst-case scenario, officials indicated, the operator may have to appoint an Indian national to the role.

The issue has also emerged as a hurdle to the airport's operational readiness. Although the airport has received its aerodrome licence, a key clearance—the Aerodrome Security Programme (ASP)—remains pending. Officials said the CEO

has neither received mandatory security clearance from the home ministry nor been vetted by BCAS, both of which are required for airport executives.

A spokesperson for the airport said the operator is working closely with BCAS to secure approval for the ASP. "Following this, we will coordinate with stakeholders to finalise timelines for the commencement of commercial operations. Our focus is on ensuring that all systems and processes are aligned for a safe and efficient launch," the spokesperson said, without commenting

on the CEO's clearance status.

The requirement stems from a BCAS aviation security (AVSEC) order issued on 17 January 2011, which stipulates that the CEO of Indian nationality at every greenfield airport will act as the security coordinator responsible for implementing aviation security measures.

Officials said the matter has been under discussion for several years. In 2022, a show-cause notice was issued to the airport operator for non-compliance with the AVSEC order, and a proposal to amend the rules was initiated, though it did not reach a conclusion.

The Noida International Airport, located in Jewar near Greater Noida, was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on 28 March. However, following the home ministry's decision, uncertainty remains over the timeline for the commencement of commercial flight operations.

# News at a Glance

## TWO HURT AS MERCEDES HITS BIKE AFTER COLLISION WITH BMW IN FBD

**FARIADABAD:** Two bike-borne youths were injured after a speeding Mercedes, which had earlier collided with a BMW, hit their motorcycle from behind on the Delhi-Agra National Highway in Faridabad, police said on Wednesday. The accident occurred late Tuesday night, after which both car drivers fled the spot. Eyewitnesses said a white BMW and a black Mercedes were racing near Escorts Mujesar Metro Station when the Mercedes first collided with the BMW and then struck the motorcycle, forcing it off the road. Some witnesses alleged the drivers appeared intoxicated. The vehicles have been seized and an investigation is underway.

**CBI NABS POLICE HEAD CONSTABLE IN BRIBERY CASE, RECOVERS RS 48L**

**NEW DELHI:** CBI arrested a Delhi Police head constable posted with the anti-narcotics cell in Dwarka for allegedly accepting Rs 2 lakh bribe from a complainant in exchange for not falsely implicating her in a case, officials said on Wednesday. According to the agency, a case was registered on Tuesday against head constable Ajay and others after a complaint of a Rs 15 lakh bribe demand. CBI laid a trap and caught him red-handed accepting Rs 2 lakh. Searches at the Dwarka office recovered Rs 48.87 lakh cash.



PETROL PUMPS, AGENCIES DIRECTED TO ENSURE STRICT COMPLIANCE WITH RULES

# Clean air drive: No PUC? No fuel

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a decisive push to curb rising air pollution, the Delhi government has announced that vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control (PUC) certificate will no longer be allowed to refuel at any petrol pump or gas station in the Capital. The stringent move signals a zero-tolerance approach towards vehicular emissions and marks a major step in enforcing environmental compliance on the ground.

Announcing the decision, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, “Tackling air pollution requires firm and effective interventions. This decision is a crucial step in that direction,” reaffirming the government’s commitment to ensuring cleaner air and a healthier environment for Delhi’s residents.

Under the new directive, fuel including petrol, diesel, CNG and LPG will be supplied strictly and exclusively to vehicles possessing a valid PUC certificate. The rule is being implemented



as a permanent measure aimed at strengthening pollution control mechanisms and ensuring strict adherence to environmental norms.

As per Rule 115 (sub-rule 7) of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, all vehicles are required to carry a valid PUC certificate after one year of registration and present it on demand. However, officials noted that a significant number of vehicles continue to ply

without valid certification, contributing heavily to the capital’s pollution burden.

The Chief Minister highlighted that the Commission for Air Quality Management, under its revised Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), has also mandated strict enforcement of PUC norms. The framework предусматривает stringent action against violators, including vehicle seizure and imposition of maximum penalties.

## ZERO-TOLERANCE

» The stringent move signals a zero-tolerance approach towards vehicular emissions and marks a major step in enforcing environmental compliance on the ground

» Tackling air pollution requires firm and effective interventions. This decision is a crucial step in that direction: CM

» Under the new directive, fuel including petrol, diesel, CNG and LPG will be supplied strictly and exclusively to vehicles possessing a valid PUC certificate

» The rule is being implemented as a permanent measure aimed at strengthening pollution control mechanisms



## Min inaugurates civic projs in Palam, Nilothi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a push to strengthen basic civic infrastructure, Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Wednesday inaugurated a series of key projects across Palam and Nilothi, targeting long-standing issues of waterlogging, traffic congestion and inadequate water and sewer services.

The projects include strengthening of embankments along the Palam Link Drain, construction of four RCC box culvert bridges in Palam, and major connectivity upgrades near Nilothi. These upgrades feature a new double-lane bridge and resurfacing of roads along the Najafgarh drain, aimed at easing daily commuting and improving accessibility in surrounding areas.

In addition, a Rs 8 crore project by the Delhi Jal Board has been launched to lay new

water supply and sewer lines in Mahavir Enclave, Ramphal Chowk, Madhu Vihar and Sadh Nagar. The initiative seeks to address long-pending concerns related to unreliable water supply and inadequate sanitation in densely populated localities.

Officials said the Palam Link Drain strengthening will enhance flood control capacity and reduce overflow risks during the monsoon, while the newly constructed culverts will improve local mobility. Similarly, the Nilothi projects are expected to significantly reduce congestion and streamline connectivity for nearby colonies.

Speaking on the occasion, Verma said, “Development is not about announcements - it is about fixing the real problems people face every day. Whether it is waterlogging, traffic, or basic services like water and sewer, our focus is to deliver visible change on the ground.”



## NDMC marks Earth Day with tree drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council on Wednesday organised a large-scale tree plantation drive at Nehru Park to mark Earth Day, bringing together foreign dignitaries, civic officials, and members of the public under the ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ campaign.

The initiative, aligned with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeks to promote environmental consciousness through public participation while encouraging citizens to plant trees in the name of their mothers.

Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal, who led the programme, described the campaign as both an environmental and emotional initiative. “Plant a tree today, nurture it tomorrow, and gift a greener future to the coming generations,” he said, highlighting the importance of sustained ecological responsibility.

The plantation drive witnessed participation from rep-

resentatives of several embassies and high commissions, including those from Poland, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, Portugal, Seychelles, the Philippines, and Guyana. Officials said the presence of international delegates underscored the role of global cooperation in addressing environmental challenges.

Chahal noted that the campaign extends beyond symbolic plantation efforts, aiming to evolve into a sustained mass movement. He added that regular plantation drives are being conducted across NDMC areas, including weekly initiatives, to ensure long-term impact.

Foreign dignitaries present at the event appreciated the Council’s efforts, stating that such initiatives not only contribute to environmental protection but also foster stronger diplomatic and cultural ties.

Senior officials from NDMC’s horticulture, health, civil, and electrical departments, along with teachers and students from NDMC schools, also participated in the drive.

## AAP fields Councillor for MCD key panel, skips Mayoral race

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Wednesday said that its councillor Jalaj Kumar Chaudhary from Shalimar Bagh has filed his nomination for the Municipal Corporation of Delhi’s (MCD) Standing Committee, even as the party decided to stay away from the mayoral polls. Meanwhile, Delhi AAP president Saurabh Bharadwaj said the party has chosen not to contest the mayoral elections, a day before nominations close.

“Despite having power at all levels, the BJP has failed to bring about any change in Delhi. The BJP does not know how to perform. Only the AAP knows how to work,” the Aam Aadmi Party leader claimed.

Bharadwaj said the decision

to abstain would allow the BJP to run the MCD and be held accountable for its performance.

The electoral college for this year’s mayoral election comprises 273 votes, including 249 councillors, 14 MLAs nominated by the Delhi Assembly, seven Lok Sabha MPs, and three Rajya Sabha members. A candidate will need 137 votes to secure victory. Leader of Opposition in the MCD Ankush Narang said Chaudhary’s nomination to the key panel would strengthen public representation.

“Even while residing in a BJP stronghold, he has always fought for the rights of the people in his area and got the work done,” Narang said.

The Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva called Bha-

ment is our priority, and we are committed to improving Delhi’s air quality through sustained and comprehensive measures,” Gupta said, urging citizens to ensure their vehicles carry valid PUC certificates at all times.

She further appealed to residents to actively participate in the fight against pollution, stressing that controlling vehicular emissions remains a key pillar of the government’s broader environmental strategy.

radwaj’s statement about not contesting the mayor’s election ridiculous. “Reality is that everyone knows the Aam Aadmi Party has already lost its majority in the MCD due to several councillors leaving the party, followed by internal division. This fragmentation continues even today, and if the AAP contests the mayor’s election, more councillors may express their dissatisfaction,” Sachdeva said.

The Standing Committee is among the most powerful bodies of the MCD, handling financial approvals and key policy decisions.

Elections for the posts of mayor, deputy mayor, and three Standing Committee members are scheduled for April 29, while nominations will close on Thursday at 5 pm.

## MCD Commissioner directs sanitation blitz in Central Zone

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar on Wednesday directed an intensive sanitation drive across the Central Zone following inspections of ongoing infrastructure and civic projects.

Khirwar, accompanied by Additional Commissioner Arun Kumar Mishra, Deputy Commissioner Shashvat Saurabh, and other senior officials, visited multiple locations to assess on-

ground conditions and review progress.

At Tajpur Pahadi in Badarpur, the Commissioner examined the feasibility of establishing a waste management facility aimed at strengthening solid waste handling in the area. Officials said the proposal is part of efforts to streamline waste processing and improve sanitation infrastructure.

The Commissioner also reviewed de-silting works at key drains, including Muslim Camp Nallah, Maharani

Bagh, and Defence Colony. Stressing the urgency ahead of the monsoon, he directed officials to ensure timely completion of works to prevent water logging and facilitate smooth drainage.

An inspection of the Purnima Sethi Multi-Specialty Hospital in Kalkaji was also undertaken in the presence of Zone Chairperson Yogita Singh. Pending issues related to the hospital were discussed, with directions issued for their early resolution.

In Defence Colony, Khirwar reviewed a Dense Carpet Road project under the CMDP scheme, emphasising adherence to quality standards and project timelines.

The Commissioner instructed officials to carry out deep-cleaning drives under strict supervision at multiple administrative levels. He also called for regular monitoring of civil works, fixing accountability for delays, and maintaining high standards of execution.

The civic body reiterated its



focus on improving sanitation, drainage, and urban infrastruc-

ture through sustained oversight and coordinated action.

## Govt to desilt Yamuna River near ITO barrage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at bolstering its flood management strategy, the Delhi government plans to take up a silt removal exercise in the Yamuna River at the ITO barrage, officials said on Wednesday.

According to officials, the work will be done to deepen the existing water channel starting from the left bank of the river near the barrage.

The ITO barrage on the Yamuna is closest to all the areas affected by flooding three years ago, including ITO, Ring Road, Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, Rajghat and nearby areas. Malfunctioning of the five gates of the barrage due to heavy silting was one of the major factors, officials said.

“It would be ensured that no hindrance is caused to the free flow of water in the trench. No silt should be taken away from the floodplain, and the water channel after work should be of regular size,” an official of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department (IFC) said.

In 2023, due to unprecedented rainfall in the catchment area of the river Yamuna, there was a huge runoff in the river, due to which the highest flood level (HFL) of 208.66 meters was observed on 13 July 2023 at the Old Railway Bridge, surpassing an earlier HFL of 207.49 meters recorded on 6 September 1978.

## HIGHLIGHTS

» According to officials, the work will be done to deepen the existing water channel starting from the left bank of the river near the barrage

» The ITO barrage on the Yamuna is closest to all the areas affected by flooding three years ago, including ITO, Ring Road, Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, Rajghat and nearby areas. Malfunctioning of the five gates of the barrage due to heavy silting was one of the major factors: Officials

According to an IFC department report, as the gates on the east end of the barrage could not be opened at the peak water level of the Yamuna, the pressure was so high that the water started spilling onto areas, roads, and colonies situated along the river in the stretch between Wazirabad and the ITO barrage.

Earlier this month, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta chaired a high-level review meeting, directing all departments to complete desilting of drains on time and ensure special arrangements at known flooding hotspots.



YELLOW WARNING OF THUNDERSTORM ISSUED IN SHIMLA

# North India sizzles as IMD predicts heatwave conditions over next 4-5 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The mercury in several parts of Delhi, Rajasthan, Haryana and West Bengal on Wednesday breached the 42-degree Celsius mark, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecasting heatwave conditions over major parts of northwest, central and eastern India in the next four to five days.

According to the IMD, parts of Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and Delhi may see heatwave conditions on April 24-25, while similar conditions are likely to prevail over parts of Uttar Pradesh (April 23-26), Rajasthan (April 24-26), Madhya Pradesh (April 23-26), Vidarbha and Chhattisgarh (April 24-27), and Gangetic West Bengal, Bihar and Jharkhand (April 22-23).

A heatwave is declared when the maximum temperature departure is 4.5 or 6.4



An Agra Municipal Corporation water sprinkler tanker sprays water to beat the heat on a hot summer day, at Agra Fort, in Agra, Uttar Pradesh, Wednesday

degrees Celsius from normal, or the actual temperature breaches the 45-degree Celsius mark.

Delhi reeled under scorching heat on Wednesday, with the maximum temperature touching 42.1 degrees Celsius at the Ridge, which was 3.7 degrees above normal.

The 24-hour change in

maximum temperatures ranged between 1.6 degrees and 1.9 degrees across stations.

The mercury also soared across Rajasthan on Wednesday, with several places recording temperatures above the 40-degree mark, the weather department said.

The state recorded a high of 43.7 degrees Celsius, with

## Highlights

» According to the IMD, parts of Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and Delhi may see heatwave conditions on April 24-25

» ‘The mercury also soared across Rajasthan on Wednesday, with several places recording temperatures above the 40-degree mark’

many places, including Pilani, Chittorgarh, Churu and Kota, sizzling at above 42 degrees Celsius.

The maximum temperature settled above normal in most parts of Haryana on Wednesday, with Narnaul the hottest at 42.5 degrees Celsius, the weather office in Chandigarh said.

Sirsa recorded a high of 41.6 degrees, followed by Hisar at 41.2 degrees, Rohtak 42.2 degrees, Karnal 40.6 degrees, Ambala 40.3 degrees, while Gurugram reported a maximum temperature of 39.2 degrees Celsius. Neighbouring Punjab also witnessed above-normal temperatures, with Bathinda reporting the highest at 41 degrees Celsius, followed by Patiala at 40.4 degrees, Ludhiana 40 degrees, and Amritsar at 39 degrees Celsius.

In Himachal Pradesh, however, the weather office in Shimla has issued a yellow warning of thunderstorm and lightning accompanied by gusty winds at isolated places from April 25-28, even as dry weather prevailed in the region.

The warning has been issued for Hamirpur, Chamba, Kangra, Kullu and Mandi districts, where winds of up to 30 to 40 kmph are likely in the coming days, it said.

## Rajnath Singh holds talks with German counterpart to boost ties

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh held talks with his German counterpart Boris Pistorius in Berlin on Wednesday to bolster strategic partnership, and the two sides inked an agreement for a defence industrial cooperation roadmap, officials said.

In his remarks, Singh said that the menace of terrorism in all its forms and manifestations must be condemned, unequivocally, without exception or justification, his comments coming on a day that marked the first anniversary of the Pahalgam terror attack. He also underlined that in times of global uncertainties, India and Germany have provided much-needed stability and strength to the global economy.

Singh held bilateral talks with Germany's Federal Minister of Defence in Berlin to further bolster the strategic defence partnership with the European nation, the defence ministry said in a statement.

"The two ministers discussed a range of bilateral security and



Defence minister Rajnath Singh holds bilateral talks with German Federal Minister of Defence Boris Pistorius, unseen, in Berlin

defence issues, including priority areas for co-development and co-production of defence equipment, especially in the field of niche technologies. They also reaffirmed the commitment to enhance military-to-military cooperation as a key pillar of the strategic partnership," it said.

Also, the 'Defence Industrial Cooperation Roadmap' and 'Implementing Arrangement for Cooperation in UN Peacekeeping Training' were inked and exchanged during the meeting, it said.

He termed his visit to Ger-

many as a symbol of deep friendship, synergy and trust.

In a post on X, Singh said, "Visited TKMS submarine building facility in Kiel, accompanied by the German Defence Minister-Mr. Boris Pistorius. An insightful visit showcasing cutting-edge technologies and advanced naval capabilities, which will be mutually beneficial for cooperation in maritime domain."

The partnership has witnessed "considerable momentum" in defence cooperation over the last few years, especially after Pistorius assumed the office of the defence minister of Germany, the statement said.

Singh brought out that the recent India-EU Security & Defence Partnership marks a significant step in deepening the collective engagement.

Both ministers agreed to leverage this framework, both bilaterally and in the wider European context for tangible outcomes that will strengthen regional stability, enhance joint capabilities and reinforce the enduring Indo-German strategic alignment. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## From Page 1

### Tamil Nadu, West Bengal

Adhikari is contesting against Trinamool Congress candidate Pabitra Kar. With multi-cornered contests in several seats and between five and 15 candidates in each constituency, the phase is expected to test parties in north Bengal and the western districts, setting the tone for the second phase of voting.

Security deployment is extensive, with 2,407 CAPF companies assigned across districts. Murshidabad has the highest deployment with 316 companies, followed by East Midnapore with 273. Additionally, 2,100 Quick Response Teams have been formed, with Murshidabad having 288 teams, East Midnapore 253, and West Midnapore 248. These teams are equipped to respond immediately to incidents such as violence or booth capturing.

Authorities have enforced prohibitory orders within 100 metres of polling stations and introduced a two-tier verification system for voters. Every booth will be under 100 per cent webcasting, with cameras placed both inside and outside polling stations. An AI-based monitoring system at control rooms will flag suspicious activities in real time and alert response teams.

Officials have warned of strict action against any irregularities, stressing uniform adherence to verification protocols. With large electorates, tight security, and closely contested battles, both states are set for a significant day of polling under intense scrutiny.

In Tamil Nadu, the contest centres on a direct face-off between the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance and the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance. Chief Minister M K Stalin is seeking another term, while AIADMK leader Edappadi K Palaniswami aims to return to power after five years. According to Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik, the electorate includes 2.93 crore women, 2.83 crore men, and 7,728 third-gender voters, along with 14,59,039 first-time voters.

Polling will be conducted at 75,064 booths across 33,133 locations, using 1,06,418 ballot units along with control units and VVPAT machines. A reserve of 20 per cent EVMs and 30 per cent VVPATs has been kept to address contingencies. Inclusive arrangements have also been made, including 325 all-women polling stations, 71 managed by persons with disabilities, and 29 run by youth. Nearly 3,98,513 voters aged 85 and above have been facilitated, many of whom have already used home voting. So far, 4,18,541 postal ballots have been received, and 1,10,595 Election Duty Certificates have been issued.

A strong enforcement drive has led to the interception of materials worth Rs 1,262 crore, including Rs 543 crore in confirmed seizures. Officials said 163 FIRs have been filed over violations, particularly involving digital platforms, and 2,180 online links have been removed or blocked. "We will act strictly as per law in

all such cases," Patnaik said, referring to instances of alleged digital inducements such as cheque-like pamphlets.

Security arrangements include the deployment of 300 companies of Central Armed Police Forces along with 83,875 state police personnel. Of the total polling stations, 5,949 located in 3,025 areas have been identified as highly sensitive. Mobile phones have been barred inside booths, though collection facilities will be provided outside. Voting will conclude at 6 pm, with counting scheduled for May 4 at 62 centres. The election has also drawn attention due to the debut of TVK founder Vijay, who is contesting from Perambur and Tiruchirappalli East.

### Delhi horror

According to investigators, there were no signs of forced entry into the house, suggesting that the accused used prior knowledge of the premises to gain access. A senior officer said the family would typically leave the house keys outside in the morning for domestic staff, and the accused was aware of this arrangement. He was also familiar with the layout of the house and the daily routine of the family members, including the time when the parents would step out.

Police believe the crime occurred between 6 am and 7 am. Officials said the accused entered the house around that time, allegedly attacked the victim, and sexually assaulted her. When she resisted, he reportedly struck her on the face and head with a stick, causing significant blunt force injuries, before strangling her with a charging cable.

After the attack, the accused fled the scene. CCTV footage reviewed by the family and police shows him entering the building and heading to the third floor where the victim lived. He was also captured on a nearby street camera carrying a backpack. Investigators are examining whether he changed clothes before escaping and whether he took the victim's mobile phone.

Police sources said the suspect had arrived in Delhi from Rajasthan's Alwar shortly before the incident. He is also wanted in a sexual assault case registered on April 21 in Rajgarh, Alwar district, where he allegedly assaulted another woman before fleeing. An FIR has been filed in that case, and Delhi Police teams have coordinated with their counterparts in Rajasthan, including visiting the accused's family.

Authorities said more than 20 police teams from various units were involved in tracking the suspect during the initial stages of the investigation. Officials added that all angles, including premeditation, insider knowledge, and possible accomplices, are being examined.

Investigators noted that the timing of the crime may have been deliberate, as two other domestic workers typically arrive later in the morning. One officer said the accused entered when a security guard was briefly away, either for tea or a break, allowing him to move unnoticed.

The case has also raised questions about background verification of domestic staff. Police said there was no immediate information available on whether the

accused had been formally verified at the time of his employment. Officials have urged residents to ensure proper verification and to avoid sharing sensitive details such as spare key locations.

The incident has shocked residents of the upscale neighbourhood, with many expressing concern about safety despite the area's reputation as a secure locality. Security has since been tightened in the vicinity.

Police said the investigation is ongoing, with teams continuing to gather evidence and reconstruct the sequence of events. Authorities have expressed confidence that the case will be pursued to its conclusion as they await forensic and postmortem findings.

### PM Modi on Pahalgam

The heinous designs of terrorists will never succeed," he said. After the Pahalgam terror attack, India carried out a retaliatory military offensive against Pakistan named Operation Sindoor, in which Indian armed forces destroyed military and terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan Occupied Kashmir.

### Cal HC stays

A division bench led by Chief Justice Sujoy Paul observed that offences relating to elections are already governed by statutory provisions under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1951, and that only authorities designated under these laws can act based on their independent discretion.

The court underscored that personal liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution can be curtailed only through procedure established by law. It further noted that even preventive action must conform strictly to statutory safeguards, adding that the term "trouble-maker" has no basis in any penal statute and cannot be used to justify coercive measures.

"In our prima facie view, the police observer has erred in issuing blanket direction by treating certain citizens as 'trouble-makers'," the bench said while staying the April 21 memo till the end of June or until further orders.

However, the court clarified that its interim order would not prevent authorities from proceeding against any individual who commits an offence under existing laws. It said police and civil authorities remain free to act in accordance with the BNS, the RP Act or any other applicable penal statute, based on their own discretion.

The bench also made it clear that any exercise of preventive detention or preventive action must strictly adhere to the relevant legal framework.

Framing a key constitutional question, the court said it would examine whether the ECI can issue such general directions under Article 324 when the field is already covered by existing statutes. It granted the poll body four weeks to file its affidavit in response.

Noting the urgency with polling scheduled imminently, the

court granted interim protection against what it termed an over-broad exercise of power.

Meanwhile, Trinamool Congress (TMC) Rajya Sabha MP and former Bengal DGP Rajeev Kumar on Wednesday alleged that 500 people in Bengal have been arrested in the past 48 hours on the basis of verbal orders from the police observers which he claimed as "gross violation" of Code of Criminal Procedure.

### SC pulls up CBI

before a high court. Shah's plea against the CBI-issued LOC was rejected by the High Court, prompting him to approach the Supreme Court.

During the hearing, Senior Advocate Siddharth Aggarwal, appearing for Shah, told the bench that neither the CBI chargesheet nor the investigation under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act led to his client's arrest. He also pointed out that Shah had obtained permission from the trial court to travel abroad in line with his bail conditions. However, he was stopped at the airport because of the LOC.

Aggarwal informed the court that Shah had not been provided a copy of the LOC. He said that in practice, such circulars are neither shared with the accused nor communicated to them in advance. "Neither there is any pre-decisional hearing, nor any intimation, nor any post-decisional hearing. One can only find out at airport immigration," he submitted, adding that the process operates as an administrative action without statutory backing.

The bench took note of the lack of transparency. Justice Nath remarked that LOCs are not confidential documents and referred to the CBI's own office memorandum, which requires reasons to be recorded for issuing such circulars. "If reasons are not given, an LOC cannot be acted upon," he observed.

Justice Mehta questioned the validity of the LOC once a court has granted travel permission. "Once the court grants permission to travel abroad, how does your LOC survive?" he asked Additional Solicitor General DP Singh, representing the CBI.

The judges also explored alternative measures. Justice Nath suggested that the trial court could direct the accused to deposit his passport, which could then be released when travel is permitted. Singh responded that recent judgments discourage impounding passports, to which Justice Mehta replied that such a requirement could be imposed as a bail condition.

Singh ultimately stated that the issue could be addressed if Shah surrenders his passport, and acknowledged that LOCs are issued under an office memorandum. However, the bench remained concerned about the broader implications.

Justice Mehta highlighted the practical consequences of the current system, noting that individuals may discover an LOC only at the airport, potentially leading to financial losses. "Suppose he is travelling business class to the US, he will lose 10-15 lakhs," he said.

He also underlined that the issue affects the fundamental right to movement and questioned whether adequate application of

mind is exercised before issuing LOCs. The court warned that if the CBI fails to present a suitable SOP, it may step in to frame guidelines itself.

The matter has been adjourned to allow the CBI time to place the LOC on record and propose a structured procedure.

### Malegaon

Three devices were placed within the premises of Hamidia Masjid and Bada Kabrastan, including one at the entrance, one in a parking area and another near a power supply room. The fourth exploded at Mushawarat Chowk, a crowded locality. The attack left 31 people dead and 312 injured.

The investigation into the blasts has undergone multiple shifts, with three agencies taking charge at different stages and arriving at conflicting conclusions. The probe initially began with local police before being handed over to the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad. The ATS arrested nine Muslim men, alleging links to the banned Students Islamic Movement of India and claiming that the conspiracy had been hatched during a wedding in May 2006. According to the ATS, several of the accused had confessed, and the bombs were assembled in Mumbai with assistance from Pakistani nationals who were declared wanted.

The case was transferred to the Central Bureau of Investigation in 2007, which broadly supported the ATS findings and continued to pursue the same set of accused. However, the direction of the investigation changed after the National Investigation Agency took over the case in 2011.

The NIA conducted a fresh probe, revisiting evidence and reconstructing the events. It concluded that the nine Muslim men had been wrongly implicated and that their confessions were obtained under coercion. The agency subsequently gave them a clean chit and supported their discharge, calling the earlier proceedings a "wastage of time of the court". The nine men, who had spent about six years in jail, were granted bail in 2011 and formally discharged in 2016. One of them had died during the course of proceedings.

In its own chargesheet filed in 2013, the NIA named a different group of accused, including the four men who were discharged on Wednesday. The agency alleged that the blasts were orchestrated by right-wing extremists linked to deceased activist Sunil Joshi. It claimed that the accused transported explosives from Indore to Malegaon and planted them at the targeted locations. According to the NIA, some of the accused had purchased bicycles used to place the bombs, and the town was deliberately chosen to trigger communal unrest.

The agency's case relied in part on a statement made by Swami Aseemanand in connection with other blast cases, including those at Ajmer Sharif and Hyderabad's Mecca Masjid. In that statement, he allegedly linked the Malegaon attack to Joshi and his associates. However, the confession was later retracted and declared involuntary.

The four accused were arrested in 2013 and spent several years in custody. In 2019, the High Court

granted them bail, noting that they had been incarcerated for over six years without trial. The court also raised questions about the strength of the prosecution's evidence, including the absence of eyewitnesses who could place the accused at the scene and doubts over identification by bicycle shop owners years after the incident.

After being granted bail, the accused initially sought discharge before the trial court. Those pleas were withdrawn, and in September 2025, a special NIA court framed charges against them. The four then approached the High Court, which in January stayed the trial proceedings, observing that a prima facie case for intervention had been made out.

The High Court's decision to quash the charges now brings the prosecution against them to an end. Meanwhile, an appeal filed by the ATS challenging the discharge of the nine earlier accused remains pending before the High Court and has not been heard since 2019.

The latest verdict also comes in the backdrop of developments in the separate 2008 Malegaon blast case, where a special court last year acquitted all seven accused, including former BJP MP Sadhvi Pragya Singh Thakur and Lt Col Prasad Purohit, citing lack of evidence.

Taken together, the outcomes in both cases underline the prolonged and complex nature of terror investigations in India, where competing theories, contested confessions and shifting investigative narratives have shaped the course of prosecutions. With Wednesday's ruling, the 2006 Malegaon blasts case currently stands without any accused facing trial, leaving unresolved questions about responsibility for one of the deadliest attacks in the town's history.

### Beijing-Delhi direct flights

According to April data, IndiGo recorded passenger load factors between 68 per cent and 85 per cent on China routes, indicating steady demand as bilateral ties show signs of improvement.

AGENCIES

### EC issues

Later, Kharge clarified that his statement was not meant in a literal sense. He said he was referring to what he described as the prime minister "terrorising" political parties and democratic institutions through alleged misuse of government machinery and central agencies. "I never said he is a terrorist in the literal sense," Kharge said, adding that his remarks were about intimidation of the opposition.

The Congress hit back at the Election Commission over the notice. Party general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the move indicated that the poll body was functioning like an "attached office of the home ministry". In a post on X, he alleged that the Commission's conduct amounted to "an assault on the Constitution" and termed it a "disgrace". The Election Commission has sought Kharge's explanation within the stipulated 24-hour deadline. MPOST

## Trump extends US-Iran ...

Continued from Page 1

"We have made it clear that if we conclude that going to Islamabad is in our national interest, we would go there. But for the time being, the decision has not yet been made," Baqaei told the BBC on Wednesday.

Baqaei said Iran's delegation had travelled to Pakistan for the first round of talks "with good faith and sense of seriousness, but you have a negotiating party that has shown its lack of seriousness, lack of good faith".

The extension of the truce effectively delayed the planned visit of a US delegation led by Vice President JD Vance to Islamabad for talks with Iranian interlocutors.

Meanwhile, the Revolutionary Guards intercepted and transferred two vessels - identified as the "MSC-FRANCESCA" and the "EPA-MINODES" - to Iranian territorial waters for inspection of their cargo, documents, and related records, Tasnim news agency reported.

Citing a statement by the Guards, it said the ships were "attempting to exit" the Strait of Hormuz when they were intercepted. Another ship, Euphoria, was stopped after being "fired upon", according to BBC.

The development came as Trump announced the extension of the ceasefire with Iran indefinitely.

"Based on the fact that the Government of Iran is seriously fractured, not unexpectedly so and, upon the request of Field Marshal Asim Munir, and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, of Pakistan, we have been asked to hold our attack on the country of Iran until such time as their leaders and representatives can come up with a unified proposal," Trump said on Tuesday.

However, Trump made it clear that the US will refrain from attacking Iran only until its leadership presents a unified proposal for negotiations. He said the economic blockade of Iran's ports will remain in place.

The US President said he has therefore "directed the military to continue the blockade".

The decision to extend the ceasefire marked a significant shift in Trump's tone. Earlier on Tuesday, he said that if a deal was not reached by Wednesday, he expected to "be bombing, because that is a better attitude to go in with."

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif expressed hope that both Iran and the US would be able to "conclude a comprehensive peace deal" to end the conflict.

"I sincerely hope that both sides will continue to observe the ceasefire and be able to conclude a comprehensive 'Peace Deal' during the second round of talks scheduled at Islamabad for a permanent end to the conflict," Sharif said.

The Iranian envoy to Pakistan, Reza Amiri Moghadam, called on PM Sharif and discussed the "ongoing regional situation and peace efforts," the PM's Office said.

Earlier, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi slammed the US, saying blockading Iranian ports is an "act of war and thus a violation of the ceasefire".

"Striking a commercial vessel and taking its crew hostage is an even greater violation. Iran knows how to neutralise restrictions, how to defend its interests, and how to resist bullying," he said in a social media post.

On Tuesday, the US said its forces boarded an oil tanker previously sanctioned for smuggling Iranian crude in Asia. The US military did not disclose the location of the boarding, though ship-tracking data showed the vessel in the Indian Ocean between Sri Lanka and Indonesia on Tuesday.

Meanwhile, Islamabad's Red Zone, where government buildings and offices are located, was under strict security. The area remained sealed to the general public on Wednesday, but other routes, sealed earlier, were opened. The army was patrolling the area.

Pakistan has taken elaborate security measures, including deploying more than 10,000 security personnel, in preparation for the proposed talks.

The first round of US-Iran talks held on April 11 and 12 failed to produce a breakthrough, prompting a flurry of diplomatic efforts by host Pakistan to cool tensions and revive hopes for another round of dialogue.



SLAM BJP OVER 'MISUSE OF INSTITUTIONS'

# Kejriwal, Thackeray back Mamata on eve of polls



Mamata Banerjee during a roadshow in support of TMC candidates, at Shibpur constituency, in Howrah PTI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Arvind Kejriwal, Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader and former Delhi Chief Minister, on Wednesday extended support to Mamata Banerjee ahead of the upcoming West Bengal Assembly elections. Kejriwal spoke to Banerjee over the phone and conveyed his “complete solidarity and support.”

Describing the 2026 Assembly elections in Bengal as “one of the most difficult” and “most important battles for Indian democracy”, Kejriwal asserted that the BJP would lose the polls.

“Just spoke to Mamata didi on the phone. Expressed complete solidarity and support. She is fighting one of the most difficult battles, which is also one of the most important battles for Indian democracy. Modi ji will lose, in spite of misusing all institutions including CEC,” he posted on X.

Kejriwal framed the elec-

The Narrative

» ‘A lone woman is fighting like a tigress; she is bound to win. To defeat this single woman, 2,00,000 CRPF personnel have been deployed...’

» ‘Just spoke to Mamta didi on the phone. Expressed complete solidarity and support. She is fighting one of the most difficult battles, which is also one of the most important battles for Indian democracy. Modi ji will lose, in spite of misusing all institutions including CEC’

tion as more than a state contest, alleging that the BJP has been exploiting institutions and agencies in its bid to capture Bengal. The political landscape in the state continues to

be marked by an intense Trinamool Congress (TMC) versus BJP rivalry, with Banerjee consistently projecting her campaign as a fight against alleged central overreach.

Meanwhile, Uddhav Thackeray, chief of Shiv Sena (UBT), on Tuesday praised Banerjee for her resistance to the BJP, saying she was “fighting like a tigress”. Referring to the heavy deployment of security forces ahead of the polls, Thackeray criticised the BJP-led Centre and backed the West Bengal Chief Minister. “A lone woman is fighting like a tigress; she is bound to win. To defeat this single woman, 2,00,000 CRPF personnel have been deployed. When Manipur was in flames, there were 30,000 troops. How is one supposed to vote?” he said.

Banerjee, in several recent rallies, has also accused the BJP-led Centre of deploying excessive central forces and misusing agencies to gain an electoral advantage in the state.

# IPAC raid row: SC says CM’s interference in ED probe not ‘Centre-State’ dispute

Top court slams Mamata, says one ‘cannot put democracy in jeopardy’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Supreme Court of India on Wednesday indicated that alleged interference by a Chief Minister in a central agency’s probe cannot automatically be framed as a Centre-State dispute, as it heard petitions by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arising from a disrupted search operation in West Bengal.

A Bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and N.V. Anjaria was dealing with the ED’s plea seeking a direction for registration of a CBI case against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and certain State police officials for allegedly obstructing a raid at the office of I-PAC, a political consultancy associated with the ruling Trinamool Congress. A connected petition by ED officers challenges an FIR lodged against them by the state police.

Key Points

» A Bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and N.V. Anjaria was dealing with the ED’s plea seeking a direction for registration of a CBI case against Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee

» At the threshold, the West Bengal government questioned the maintainability of the petitions under Article 32 of the Constitution

» The state further contended that the ED cannot invoke fundamental rights jurisdiction

At the threshold, the West Bengal government questioned the maintainability of the petitions under Article 32 of the Constitution of India. Senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy argued that the dispute was, in substance, between the Union and the State and should be pursued under Article 131 of the Constitution of India before the apex court.

The Bench, however, expressed reservations,

observing that the controversy appeared to concern the conduct of an individual holding constitutional office rather than an intergovernmental dispute. It remarked that permitting such characterisation could blur accountability where executive interference in investigations is alleged.

The state further contended that the ED, being a statutory authority, cannot invoke fundamental rights jurisdiction. Hearings will continue.

Senior advocate Abhishek Manu Singhvi argued that neither the agency nor its officers possess enforceable fundamental rights in the discharge of official duties, relying on Constitution Bench rulings that non-citizens and juristic entities cannot claim rights under Article 19. He also maintained that Articles 14, 21 and 22 were not attracted.

Guruswamy additionally urged that the case raises an unprecedented constitutional question warranting reference to a Constitution Bench under Article 145 of the Constitution of India. The court was unconvinced, noting that not every legal issue necessitates such referral. The ED opposed the objections, even as the Bench continued to examine whether a central agency can maintain a writ against a State alleging obstruction of investigation. Hearings will continue.

# ‘Babbar sher’: Rahul meets AI meet protesters

NEW DELHI: Former Congress chief Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday met the Indian Youth Congress members who were arrested for a “shirtless” protest during the AI Impact Summit here in February and said he is proud of the courage and patriotism of these “lions”.

This was Gandhi’s first joint meeting with all the Youth Congress members who were arrested following the protest. The leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha shared photographs of the meeting held at the Congress headquarters here on his Instagram page.

“Today, I met with my fellow ‘babbar sher (lion)’ members of the Youth Congress who had been arrested for their peaceful protest. Peaceful protest is a constitutional right of every citizen. And it becomes all the more essential -- especially when the country’s Prime Minister is compromised,” Gandhi said.

MPOST

# ‘BJP misleading on women’s quota’

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday alleged the BJP of ‘deceiving democracy’ and deliberately creating confusion regarding women’s reservation to mislead the public.

“The Women’s Reservation Law has already been passed by Parliament with consensus in 2023. Yet the BJP leaders do not stop spreading lies. They resort to propaganda to divert attention from core issues like corruption, loot, inflation, and unemployment because they are terrified of the unity of the PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak),” he said.

Addressing a meeting of former candidates and leaders from constituencies reserved for Scheduled Castes and Sched-

uled Tribes at the party headquarters here, Yadav, according to a party statement, alleged that the BJP treats SP workers like “enemies” and operates with “low-level” conduct.

“BJP is an organised gang whose primary agenda is to spread hatred and create division in society. The BJP is deceiving democracy. Their conduct is sub-standard, and they treat Samajwadi Party workers as if they are enemies,” Yadav said.

Exhorting party cadres to prepare for the 2027 Assembly elections, Yadav said the public has lost faith in the current government, and the BJP is already functioning like an “opposition party” due to its waning influence.

MPOST

# ‘Nagrikdevo Bhava’ must influence every decision: PM to civil servants

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has written letters to over a crore civil servants telling them that the principle of ‘Nagrikdevo Bhava’ (citizen is god) must be at the heart of every decision and the government must serve the people to the best of its abilities.

The Prime Minister also conveyed to the civil servants that governance must be grounded in compassion and that those who bear the responsibility of public service must themselves be the finest examples of lifelong learning.

The letters, written on April 20, a day ahead of Civil Services Day, were issued in 12 languages — Hindi, English, Marathi, Odia, Gujarati, Bengali, Kannada, Punjabi, Assa-



mese, Malayalam, Telugu and Tamil — ensuring wider reach across Ministries, Departments, States and Union Territories.

Modi said the 21st century is a time of great challenges as well as opportunities and trends are changing every day, new technologies are emerging and new innovations are constantly happening.

He said both the citizens and the world have great expecta-

tations from the country.

“It is important that the government’s services and work culture are tuned to make the maximum out of this historic era. Making learning a lifelong habit through the use of platforms such as the iGOT Karmayogi platform is important in this regard. You are choosing to be better so that Bharat can be better,” he said.

Addressing the civil servants as ‘Karmayogi’, the Prime Minister said he has written the letter to them at a very special time, as in many parts of India, it is a festive season. He said the atmosphere is filled with the enthusiasm of Rongali Bihu, Vishu, Puthandu, Poila Boishakh, Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti and Baisakhi.

MPOST

# Baramati bypoll: Sympathy wave may aid Sunetra Pawar

NEW DELHI: Riding a sympathy wave ahead of Thursday’s byelection to the Baramati assembly constituency, Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar has urged voters to support her as a tribute to her late husband Ajit Pawar.

Voting for the byelection, necessitated by then Deputy Chief Minister and NCP chief Ajit Pawar’s death in an air crash on January 28, is scheduled to take place on Thursday with 23 candidates including Sunetra Pawar in the fray.

While the election is expected to be a cake-walk for Sunetra Pawar, it remains to be seen whether she would win by a record margin like her late husband. Local NCP leaders are unsure about voter turnout as they fear that people may take Sunetra Pawar’s victory for granted and skip voting.

In her concluding speech on Tuesday, Sunetra Pawar made an emotional appeal, saying that every vote for her would be a fitting tribute to Ajit ‘Dada’ (elder brother).

She would ensure that Ajit Pawar’s dreams and vision for the constituency are carried forward and fulfilled, said Sunetra who was sworn in as deputy CM days after her husband’s death. She had no ministerial experience prior to it.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who also addressed the concluding rally on Tuesday, urged voters to come out in large numbers and vote for Sunetra ‘Vahini’ (sister-in-law), saying that April 23 is the day to express love for and pay tribute to Ajit Dada.

It was expected that major political parties would not field their candidates against Sunetra in keeping with convention.

AGENCIES

# Rahul says Mamata’s polarisation gave BJP entry in West Bengal

KOLKATA: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday appealed to the people of West Bengal to vote for the Congress and said that if Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee had run a clean government and not polarised the state, then the BJP would not have got an opening there.

In a video statement issued on the eve of the first phase of the West Bengal polls, Gandhi stressed that the Congress takes on the BJP which knows that only the Congress can stop it.

“This is an election of ideologies. The first thing I want to tell you is that the BJP steals elections. The BJP has stolen elections in Haryana, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh. The SIR (Special Intensive Revision) is a means to steal elections,” the leader of opposition

in the Lok Sabha said.

The ideologies of the BJP and the Congress are fighting it out in the country, he said.

“In our 4000-km-long Bharat Jodo Yatra, we had given just one message --nafrat ke bazaar mein mohabbat ki dukaan kholni hai,” Gandhi said.

He further alleged that the BJP works against Bengali culture, history and language.

“BJP leaders say ‘One Nation, One Language, One Religion’. In this country there are diverse languages, people, religions and ideologies. The Constitution states that India that is Bharat is a Union of states. We are protecting the Constitution and the BJP is attempting to finish off the Constitution,” he alleged.

“If Mamata (Banerjee) ji

had run a clean government, if (TMC’s) Mamata ji had not polarised Bengal, then the BJP would not have gotten an opening,” Gandhi said.

The Congress takes on the BJP which knows that only the Congress can stop it, he asserted.

Gandhi urged people to support and vote for the Congress and form its government in West Bengal. Tagging his video statement, Gandhi said in a post on X, “Brothers and sisters of West Bengal, in this battle of ideologies, only the Congress can defeat the BJP. They snatch away rights; we restore them. They seek to dismantle the Constitution; we protect it. They wish to erase India’s diversity; we, alongside Bengal, respect every culture and every language.”

AGENCIES

# Shah claims Cong may draw a blank in Bengal

KOLKATA: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday mounted a sweeping attack on both the Congress and the ruling TMC, claiming that Rahul Gandhi’s party would fail to win even a single seat in West Bengal, and that Mamata Banerjee’s proximity to the Congress would hasten her political decline.

Addressing a poll rally at Dum Dum area, Shah sought to stitch together several of the BJP’s principal poll planks in Bengal — from infiltration and women’s safety to ‘syndicate raj’, dynastic politics and the Babri Masjid issue — while projecting the contest as a decisive battle to end what he called the TMC’s “politics of terror”.

“I want to tell Rahul Gandhi that in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, you will not even



Amit Shah campaigns in support of BJP candidate Sourav Sikdar PIC/PTI

cross double digits. In West Bengal, you may not even be able to open your account, and in Assam, the Congress will face its biggest defeat ever,” he said.

In a more expansive attack on the Congress leadership, Shah accused party president Mallikarjun Kharge of lowering the level of political discourse under Rahul Gandhi’s influence.

“Narendra Modi ji, who

eradicated terrorism, is being called a terrorist by Kharge ji. Staying around Rahul Gandhi has started to corrupt Kharge ji’s language, too. Listen up, Rahul Gandhi... The more abuses you hurl at Modi ji, the more mud you sling with your insults, the lotus will bloom with even greater pride,” he asserted.

Training his guns at Banerjee, Shah said the chief minister

# Shah sought to stitch BJP’s several key poll planks in Dum Dum rally

was making a political mistake by aligning herself with the Congress.

“Mamata didi, you are sitting with this same Congress. Your situation is also going to worsen,” he said. The BJP leader also sought to counter the TMC’s charge that the saffron party would impose an “outsider” as CM if voted to power in Bengal. “She is misleading people by saying that Bengal will have an outsider as chief minister. The CM will be someone from Bengal. However, it will not be Mamata’s ji’s nephew, but a BJP CM,” Shah said.

MPOST

# Gujarat local polls: BJP looks comfortably placed, Cong and AAP face credibility challenge

BJP has claimed victory in 731 seats without contest due to the withdrawal of nominations

AHMEDABAD: The forthcoming elections to local bodies in Gujarat are expected to reflect the mood of voters ahead of the 2027 assembly polls in a state where the BJP’s political dominance remains unshaken, even as the Congress and AAP are attempting to chip away at the saffron citadel.

For the BJP, the challenge lies in retaining its political dominance of around three decades in the home state of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah.

Interestingly, while the polling is four days away, the BJP has claimed victory in 731 seats without contest due to the withdrawal of nominations by some candidates fielded by the opposition parties, according to a spokesperson.

Polling for 15 municipal corporations, 34 district panchayats, 260 taluka panchayats and 84 municipalities will be held on April 26 for 9,992 seats. Votes will be counted on April 28.

Political analysts believe



Gujarat Deputy CM Harsh Sanghavi being received by BJP workers during a public rally PTI

that the outcome of the elections is likely to reveal the mood of the people before next year’s assembly elections.

The BJP is banking on the development track record, while the Congress and the AAP are hoping that “resentment” among voters will boost their prospects in some pockets.

The BJP mainly relies on its biggest mascot, PM Modi, the development agenda, and the performance of the Bhupendra Patel government.

Conversely, the Congress, the other extreme of the BJP-dominated binary politics in Gujarat, believes that the results will be a big jolt to the ruling party ahead of the 2027 assembly polls.

In a first for AAP, which is trying to expand its footprint in the state, the Arvind Kejriwal-led party is contesting on around 5,000 seats in local polls.

In March 2021, the BJP scored a landslide once again in local polls in Gujarat, win-

Takeaways

» For the BJP, the challenge lies in retaining its political dominance of around three decades in the home state of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah

» Polling for 15 municipal corporations, 34 district panchayats, 260 taluka panchayats and 84 municipalities will be held on April 26 for 9,992 seats. Votes will be counted on April 28

ning 6,236 out of 8,470 seats across various municipalities and establishing a wide gap with rival Congress.

The BJP had then dominated all six municipal corporations, besides 81 municipalities, 32 district panchayats, and 231 taluka panchayats.

In January 2026, the Gujarat cabinet approved the conversion of nine municipalities into municipal corporations—Navsari, Gandhidham, Morbi, Vapi, Anand, Nadiad, Mehsana, Porbandar and Surendranagar,

a first in the last 14 years.

“This time the BJP will be surprised as the common people are angry with the ruling party over large-scale corruption in local self-governing bodies, bad management at local bodies, and non-fulfilment of promises,” claimed Gujarat Congress spokesperson Manish Doshi.

Citing the Congress’s impressive performance in various municipal corporations and municipalities, Doshi said the poll outcome will be a wake-up call for the BJP ahead of the assembly elections.

He accused the BJP of using money and muscle power to silence the Opposition, highlighting uncontested victories ahead of polling in a few seats.

“The BJP forced some of our candidates to withdraw from the fray with money and muscle power to win elections uncontested. However, they could do so in a few seats. Congress workers and candidates are resisting such high-handedness bravely,” he said.

AGENCIES

## Nation Briefs

### PM MODI’S VARANASI VISIT: BJP PREPARES FOR WOMEN’S CONFERENCE

VARANASI: Preparations have intensified in Varanasi ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s proposed visit to the city on April 28, with the BJP and its Mahila Morcha stepping up efforts. BJP’s Kashi region president Dilip Patel said the party’s district and city units have planned a booth-level outreach campaign to make a proposed women’s conference during Modi’s visit historic. Patel said the prime minister will arrive in Varanasi on the afternoon of April 28 and inaugurate projects worth crores at the Banaras Locomotive Works. He will then address the massive women’s conference.

### FADNAVIS SLAMS KHARGE OVER HIS REMARKS ON PM MODI, SEEKS APOLOGY

MUMBAI: Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday said Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge’s remarks, calling Prime Minister Narendra Modi a “terrorist”, were “derogatory” and “unacceptable”, and asked him to apologise. Talking to reporters after a cabinet meeting in Mumbai, Fadnavis insisted the Congress leader’s comments reflected “frustration” stemming from repeated electoral defeats of his outfit and alleged that such statements were part of the Opposition party’s long-standing political approach. “Using inappropriate language against a leader who is a matter of national pride and has contributed to building a modern India is condemnable,” he maintained.



# After one year, resilience and resolve as Pahalgam picks up pieces

While Baisaran remains closed, other areas in and around are open to visitors

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**PAHALGAM/NEW DELHI:** It was a day of recall, remembrance and resilience. A year after three Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorists opened fire at tourists in Pahalgam's Baisaran meadow, 26 families on Wednesday observed the death anniversary of their loved ones and political leaders said in unison that the country would not bow to terror.

At the picturesque grassland of Baisaran, fringed by mountains and dubbed a mini Switzerland, the months of quiet that followed the terror attack have slowly given way to the bells of pony rides and the shutter-click of cameras as tourists begin to return.

While Baisaran remains closed, other areas in and around are open to visitors.

"Remembering the innocent lives lost in the gruesome Pahalgam terror attack on this



Tourists take a horse ride amid heightened security on the first anniversary of the Pahalgam terror attack, at Pahalgam in Anantnag district, Wednesday PTI

day last year. They will never be forgotten... As a nation, we stand united in grief and resolve. India will never bow to any form of terror. The heinous designs of terrorists will never succeed," said Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"Such acts of terror cannot deter our unwavering commitment to peace and unity," said President Droupadi Murmu.

The terror attack by the Pakistan-based LeT, which tar-

geted tourists, killing 25 men who had gone to Kashmir for a holiday and a pony wallah, is the deadliest in recent years. The killings triggered a four-day military conflict with Pakistan after Indian armed forces retaliated on May 7 by targeting terror infrastructure in Pakistan-controlled territories in the operation named 'Sindoor'.

The Indian Army in a statement reaffirmed its steely resolve

### Highlights

» 'Such acts of terror cannot deter our unwavering commitment to peace and unity,' said President Murmu

» Away from the political debates, 26 families from across the country mourned their irreparable loss

cies and alleged that the government had failed to keep Pakistan diplomatically isolated on the global stage.

Away from the political debates, 26 families from across the country mourned their irreparable loss.

"That day, I lost everything in my life. Even today, I cannot forget that incident. Whenever I close my eyes, the incident comes back to me," said Priyadarshini Satpathy from Odisha's Balasore district. Her husband Prashant Kumar Satpathy was among those killed.

"I am managing to somehow survive, because after he left, everything is gone - the happiness of my home and all the happiness in my life," she said, adding that the government provided Rs 20 lakh as financial assistance but other promises, including a government job and support for her children's education, are yet to be fulfilled.

## Prepare report on challenges faced by textile sector: Saini to officials

### MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini directed officials to prepare a separate report on the difficulties being faced by industrialists from Panipat, Sonipat, Faridabad, Hisar, and other districts associated with the textile sector.

He said districts such as Panipat and Faridabad in Haryana are among the highest exporters in the country. At present, this industry needs support, and the new Haryana Industrial Policy 2026 will prove to be a milestone for the state's textile sector. Saini said this while interacting with textile exporters from the state at Haryana Bhawan in New Delhi on Wednesday.

During discussions on the draft Haryana Industrial Policy 2026, Chief Minister has been meeting representatives of major industrial units and groups with recognition at the state, national, and global levels.

He specifically allocated separate time to interact with heads of textile industry units from the state. Key challenges being faced by the textile sector were discussed in detail. It was noted that the issues of this industry are distinct in nature. The CM directed officials to prepare a separate report on the difficulties being faced by industrialists from Panipat, Sonipat, Faridabad, Hisar, and other districts associated with the textile sector.

In the evening session, more than 15 leading industrialists participated.



Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini being felicitated by representatives of the textile industry in New Delhi MPOST

Haryana: 16 students create history in IIT-JEE Main

### MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** Haryana Education minister Mahipal Dhandra said that the state government's ambitious initiative, Haryana Super 100, has once again set a new benchmark in the field of education by delivering exceptional results.

He informed that 16 students associated with the programme secured 99-plus percentile in IIT-JEE Main 2026 (Session-2), bringing pride to the state at the national level. He said this achievement is an inspiration not only for Haryana but also for government schools across the country.

## Madhya Pradesh HC orders check posts restored to curb overloading, boost road safety

### SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

**BHOPAL:** In a significant ruling aimed at curbing illegal overloading and ensuring road safety, the Madhya Pradesh High Court has directed the state government to restore all interstate transport check posts within 30 days.

The order, passed by the single bench of Justice Vishal Mishra, comes as a major setback to the state's earlier decision to dismantle these interstate check posts.

The High Court was hearing a contempt petition filed by Rajneesh Tripathi, who alleged that the state government had wilfully disobeyed its prior undertakings. Previously, in a Public Interest Litigation (W.P. No. 12203/2006) regarding the



menace of overloading, the State had assured the court of a 'working plan' that included the continuous operation of check posts to intercept overloaded vehicles at the borders.

However, on June 30, 2024, the state authorities took a 'somersault' and issued orders to close all interstate check posts from July 1, 2024. Petitioner's advocates, Jubin Prasad and Bhanu

Prakash, argued that this move led to a surge in road accidents and environmental damage, directly violating the court's stay order from September 2018.

Justice Mishra dismissed the State's defence that 'alternative modes' like mobile units (Check points) were sufficient. The Court noted that failure to follow an undertaking given to a

Division Bench constitutes wilful disobedience.

"The reply submitted by the Authorities is not satisfactory... this amounts to disobedience of the order passed by this Court and the undertaking given by respondents," the bench observed.

The HC has granted the state 30 days from the receipt of the certified order to restore the closed posts. Failure to comply within this timeframe grants the petitioner the liberty to revive contempt proceedings against the concerned officials. While the state remains free to use other surveillance methods, the court emphasised that the original commitment to physical check posts must be

honoured to protect public property and lives.

## Govt to host 9th 'India International Water Week' from September 22-26

Focus on climate-resilient water management

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Ministry of Jal Shakti will host the 9th edition of India International Water Week (IIWW-2026) from September 22 to 26 at Bharat Mandapam, centred on the theme "Climate Resilient Water Management".

The event was formally launched in the national capital by Union Jal Shakti minister C R Patil, who also released the official brochure and unveiled the event website.

Leadership from the federal water ministry presided over early proceedings. In the city's core, formal initiation occurred



alongside digital access activation. Printed material made its debut during the introductory function. C R Patil, minister overseeing the portfolio, guided launch activities into motion.

Among those attending the event was V L Knatha Rao, serving as secretary of water resources, river development and Ganga rejuvenation.

In attendance also stood Ashok K K Meena, holding the post in drinking water and sanitation. Several additional senior officers from the ministry formed part of the gathering.

Addressing the gathering, the minister expressed confidence that IIWW-2026 will bring together global experts, policymakers, innovators, and stakeholders to exchange knowledge and best practices in water management.

From there emerged mention of Prime Minister Narendra Modi urging broad public involvement through the Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari effort.

### MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** Former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda has said that the BJP government's anti-women reservation policy and intent stands exposed before the country.

He strongly condemned the BJP government's double standards regarding women's reservation and the deliberate delays being orchestrated.

Addressing a special press conference, Hooda cited historical facts, constitutional procedures, and timelines. He clarified that women's reservation has been a long-standing commitment of the Congress party.



Women register themselves during the self-enumeration process under the Census of India 2027, in Patna PTI

house listing and housing census, and the second is the population census.

Field visits for the housing listing and housing census began on April 16 in several states and Union territories. They will list all structures, houses, and households nationwide to provide a solid foundation for the population enumeration.

The month-long exercise will be notified by each state

and Union territory between April 1 and September 30. The field visits will be preceded by a 15-day window for self-enumeration, during which citizens can answer HLO phase questions via a portal.

Citizens will generate a special ID after filling in the required details and answering the questions, which they will provide to enumerators who visit their homes during the HLO process for verification.

## Punjab to explore feasibility of bringing 'Solein protein'

In Mid-Day Meals, Anganwadi programmes

### MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, during his visit to Finland, placed the Punjabi diaspora at the centre of Punjab's next phase of growth, calling on global Punjabis to actively contribute to the state's ongoing transformation while simultaneously pushing for stronger economic and institutional collaboration between Punjab and Finland.

Engaging with the diaspora, the Chief Minister underscored that Punjab is witnessing rapid development and asserted that every Punjabi must become a partner in

this historic journey, describing the global community as a decisive force capable of accelerating the state's economic momentum.

Interacting with the Punjabi diaspora in Finland, CM Mann urged them to play an active role in the socio-economic development of Punjab.

He said, "Punjab is making rapid development during the current regime and every Punjabi should be a part of this historic move."

He added that the diaspora can act as a catalyst in further propelling the economic development of the state through their expertise.

## Punjab to conduct civil defence air raid mock exercises on April 24

### MPOST BUREAU

**CHANDIGARH:** In order to test the Civil Defence Preparedness in the state, the Punjab State will conduct a Civil Defence Air Raid/Blackout Mock Exercise on April 24.

The exercise is being conducted in all districts of the state as per the directives of the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India, New Delhi.

The Mock Exercise will commence with an Air Raid Warning Signal, which will be disseminated through sirens featuring a high-low pitch for a duration of two minutes. During the course of the exercise, a simulated blackout will be enforced in specific areas identified by the respective Deputy Commissioners-cum-Controllers, Civil Defence. The general public in these identified areas is instructed to switch off all non-essential lighting during the blackout period.

However, essential services shall remain fully functional throughout the drill.

## Madhya Pradesh farmers to get fourfold compensation for acquired land

The Cabinet decision under 'Krishak Kalyan Varsh' aims to boost farmer incomes, ease land acquisition and speed up infrastructure projects

### SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

**BHOPAL:** Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Wednesday announced a major relief for farmers, stating that those whose agricultural land is acquired for development projects in rural areas will now receive up to four times the market value as compensation.

Addressing a press conference after the Cabinet meeting at his official residence, the Chief Minister said the state government has approved an increase in the multiplication factor for rural land acquisition from 1.0 to 2.0 under the state rules framed pursuant to the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013.

"With this historic decision taken in the 'Krishak Kalyan Varsh', farmers in rural areas will be entitled to compensation



of up to four times the market value of their land," Yadav said, describing the move as farmer-centric and transformative.

The decision follows directions issued by the Chief Minister during a high-level review meeting on November 7, 2025, where he had called for revisiting the state's land acquisition policy and studying best practices from across the country.

Subsequently, a high-powered ministerial committee was constituted on January 13, 2026, which held consultations with over 400 stakeholders, including farmer groups, social organisations, and industry bodies such as CREDAI and FICCI.

Based on the committee's recommendations, the Cabinet

### Key Points

- » Rural multiplier doubled: Raised to 2.0, enabling up to fourfold compensation
- » Immediate effect: Implements from April 22, 2026; covers pending cases without final award
- » Stakeholder-driven reform: Based on panel consultations with 400+ groups
- » Infra push: Expected to ease land acquisition hurdles and fast-track projects

approved amendments to the Madhya Pradesh Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Rules, 2015, fixing the rural multiplication factor at 2.0. The provision for urban areas will remain unchanged at 1.0.

The new compensation structure has come into effect from April 22, 2026, and will apply to all land acquisition cases where the final award has not yet been passed.

Yadav said the decision is expected to positively impact infrastructure projects such

as irrigation schemes, roads, bridges, railway lines and dams by ensuring fair compensation and reducing resistance to land acquisition. The move is also aimed at improving the economic condition of farmers and accelerating project execution across the state.

Calling it a transparent and pro-people reform, the Chief Minister said the policy would strengthen farmers' financial security while making them active stakeholders in Madhya Pradesh's development trajectory.

## CRPF's 46 gazetted officers graduated at ceremonial parade



### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** 46 Directly Appointed Gazetted Officers (DAGOs) of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) completed their training. The event featured an exact march sequence alongside traditional military displays. A pledge was taken - unwavering commitment to national duty stood at its core. The ceremony concluded without delay or disruption.

Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar, the Chief Guest, took the salute and praised the discipline, confidence, and exactness - these traits stood out clearly among the assembled officers, earning quiet approval. Following that, the piping began; families joined CRPF leaders beside

the stage. Ranks changed hands not through protocol alone but through embraces, glances, and gestures passed between parents and children and spouses and siblings. The act carried weight - not loud, yet deep.

With quiet strength, the force upholds what binds the nation together. Seen by the Minister as an emblem of courage, selflessness, truth, and duty. Facing shifting threats within, he holds trust in those recently joined to respond without delay. Their path was marked not by words but by steady resolve.

Forty-six trainees form the 56th intake, among them two female officers, representing 14 different states. Engineering backgrounds appear frequently, seen in 19 cases, suggesting a focus on technical expertise.





EDITORIAL  
REGULATING  
DIGITAL SPEECH?

The rapid expansion of artificial intelligence in the digital ecosystem has forced governments across the world to confront a difficult question: how should synthetic content be regulated without undermining the openness of the internet? In India, this debate has now taken a sharper turn with the Centre’s proposal to tighten the Information Technology Rules, particularly by mandating continuous and clearly visible labelling of AI-generated content. At first glance, the move appears both logical and necessary. In an era where deepfakes can convincingly mimic reality, the need to clearly distinguish between authentic and synthetic content is undeniable. Yet, as with most regulatory interventions in the digital domain, the implications of this proposal extend far beyond its stated objective.

The core change being proposed is deceptively simple. The earlier requirement of “prominent visibility” for AI labels is now sought to be replaced with a mandate that such labels remain visible throughout the entire duration of the content. This shift addresses a genuine loophole. A fleeting label at the beginning or end of a video is easily missed, especially in a consumption environment where users frequently join content midstream. By insisting on a persistent, always-on marker, the government is attempting to ensure that users are not misled at any point during their engagement with digital content. In principle, this is a step towards greater transparency and informed consumption.

The rationale behind the proposal is rooted in a real and growing problem. The misuse of AI tools to create hyper-realistic but entirely fabricated videos has already begun to distort public discourse. From political misinformation to financial scams, synthetic media has demonstrated its capacity to erode trust at scale. In such a context, labelling is not merely a technical requirement; it is a democratic necessity. If users cannot distinguish between what is real and what is artificially generated, the very foundation of informed citizenship is weakened. The government’s push for stricter labelling, therefore, reflects a recognition of the seriousness of this threat.

However, the effectiveness of such a mandate will depend heavily on its implementation. Requiring platforms like YouTube, Meta, and X to ensure compliance is only one part of the solution. The larger challenge lies in the decentralised nature of content creation itself. AI tools are increasingly accessible to ordinary users, and enforcing uniform standards across millions of creators is no trivial task. Moreover, the technical feasibility of embedding persistent labels across all formats—especially in short-form, edited, or re-uploaded content—raises practical questions. Without robust and standardised technological solutions, the rule risks becoming more aspirational than enforceable.

More importantly, the proposed amendment cannot be viewed in isolation. It is part of a broader set of changes to the IT Rules that have triggered significant concern among digital rights advocates. The move to make government advisories legally binding on intermediaries marks a substantial shift in the regulatory landscape. Traditionally, advisories have served as guidance rather than enforceable directives. Transforming them into binding obligations effectively expands the executive’s authority over online platforms, raising questions about checks and balances. Critics argue that such provisions blur the line between regulation and control, particularly in a domain as sensitive as online speech.

Similarly, the proposal to bring influencers and individual content creators under the same regulatory framework as formal digital news publishers introduces a new layer of complexity. While the intent may be to ensure accountability in the dissemination of news and current affairs content, the practical implications could be far-reaching. The digital ecosystem thrives on a diversity of voices, many of whom operate outside traditional institutional structures. Subjecting them to the same compliance requirements as established media organisations risks imposing disproportionate burdens, potentially stifling independent expression and innovation.

The concerns raised by groups such as the Internet Freedom Foundation highlight another critical dimension of the debate: the process of policymaking itself. Frequent amendments, overlapping consultations, and evolving proposals can create what has been described as “consultation fatigue”. When stakeholders are required to respond to multiple, shifting drafts within short timeframes, the quality of public engagement inevitably suffers. Effective regulation, particularly in a rapidly evolving field like artificial intelligence, demands not just responsiveness but also coherence and predictability.

There is also the question of legal clarity. The apprehension that binding advisories could create a “perpetual compliance threat” for intermediaries is not without merit. In the absence of clearly defined limits, such powers could be used in ways that extend beyond their original intent. For a country that has consistently emphasised the importance of digital innovation and startup growth, regulatory uncertainty can have a chilling effect. Platforms may adopt overly cautious approaches to avoid potential penalties, leading to excessive content moderation and the inadvertent suppression of legitimate speech.

Yet, it would be equally misplaced to dismiss the government’s concerns outright. The challenge of regulating AI-generated content is not unique to India, and policymakers globally are grappling with similar dilemmas. The balance between preventing harm and preserving freedom is inherently delicate. In this context, the proposal for continuous labelling represents a targeted intervention that addresses a specific and identifiable risk. If implemented with clarity, transparency, and adequate safeguards, it could enhance user awareness without unduly restricting expression.

The way forward lies in striking this balance with care. First, the labelling requirement must be accompanied by clear technical standards that ensure uniformity across platforms and tools. Second, any expansion of regulatory powers—whether through binding advisories or extended compliance frameworks—must be anchored firmly in law, with adequate oversight mechanisms. Third, the consultation process must be streamlined to enable meaningful participation from all stakeholders, including civil society, industry, and independent creators.

Ultimately, the debate over AI labelling is a microcosm of a larger transition. As technology reshapes the way information is created and consumed, regulatory frameworks must evolve in tandem. The objective should not be to control the digital space, but to make it more transparent, accountable, and trustworthy. India’s proposed amendments to the IT Rules signal an important step in this direction, but their success will depend on how well they reconcile the twin imperatives of innovation and freedom.

NEXUS  
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS  
AN AUTHOR AND  
A FORMER  
CIVIL SERVANT

Land disputes remain a persistent rural challenge, often escalating into conflict; Basti’s focused administrative approach shows how efficiency and intent can ensure timely, effective justice delivery

Ending Rural Land Gridlock

A young district collector’s systematic reforms turn a backlog of land disputes into a case study in efficient, people-centric governance

Land disputes lead to a variety of problems. In rural areas, they get compounded because of illiteracy, lack of awareness, and inadequate knowledge about laws. There is a huge cost of these delays in terms of time and money, but it all goes unnoticed and unattended. These delays have other implications as well. A large number of crimes committed can be traced back to land disputes.

Unlike other civil and criminal disputes, those relating to land in rural areas are handled by the district administration in the form of revenue cases. Hence, the role of the district administration becomes extremely critical in settling/deciding upon these disputes. This was true of the Basti district as well in Uttar Pradesh.

In September 2025, a young IAS officer, Vamsi Andra, was appointed as the District Collector of Basti district. Most of the denizens of this district are largely employed in agriculture and agro-based small-scale industries.

The Problem

Soon after taking over as Collector, Vamsi Andra found out that, of the long list of cases in the district, most were related to mutation, correction of records, title declaration, measurement and demarcation of land, removal of encroachment upon government lands, consolidation, revenue collections in terms of stamp duty, cases under the Gangster Act, validation of pattas (land deeds), and correction of maps. He soon came to the conclusion that, in an agrarian structure, the major economic activities of most residents are tied to farming, where field issues related to land paymaish (measurements), medh (farm boundaries), nali (drainage), kharanja (pavement), and batwara (fund allocation) were very prominent. These were petty disputes where people wasted their time unnecessarily.

The Philosophy: Justice Delayed is Justice Denied

Vamsi felt that when two people fight, there would be disputes, and if petty issues linger, the dispute would become complicated. Such circumstances also promote animosities among them, at times leading to criminal activities. So, justice should be delivered on time, as justice delayed is justice denied. He worked on this mantra. He was clear in his mind: a person should not have to visit the court for long periods repeatedly. The priority was to resolve these cases as soon as possible.



A local governance model that proves speed and intent can redefine justice delivery

The Strategy: Systematic Monitoring

A strategy of systematic monitoring was worked out. A summary of long-standing cases was prepared. A systematic, daily status monitoring report of each and every case was put in place. The number of new filings and the number of old filings between one year and five years was finalised. The reasons for delays in settling these disputes were analysed and discussed with the presiding officers. The officers themselves came up with very useful suggestions. More often than not, advocates sought postponement of hearings on account of frivolous reasons, and their requests were granted as a matter of routine. One of the suggestions was to seek written arguments from the counsels if they were not in a position to attend the court personally. The idea was to keep postponing dates because the counsels could not attend on account of some reason or the other. On many occasions, the officers themselves were ostensibly tied up with more pressing engagements. The importance of attending courts was conveyed

to the officers, and their attendance was closely monitored. This helped enormously, as the presiding officers now appreciated the importance of attending the court regularly.

Officers were given daily targets. If the counsel was not present, the presiding officers were authorised to go to the field and dispose of issues based on the written statements given by the plaintiff as well as the complainant.

Impact

Narrating the woes that were brought to the family because of the year-long pending case, Laxmi tells The Better India, “We had married off our daughter and have also been bearing medical expenses of Rs 20,000 a month. To manage these expenses, we took a loan worth Rs 5 lakh. To repay the loan amounts, we needed to sell the land. So, we brought our case to the notice of the concerned officers, but nobody listened to us.”

This January, her case was resolved. She profusely thanked the administration for resolving the issue in just a couple of hearings. She got permission to sell her land. “There were people in our village whose cases were pending for as long as five years; their cases were resolved too,” adds the farmer, who lives in Palha village in Basti.

What is mentioned above is just anecdotal evidence. However, even the empirical data reveal a drastic

reduction in the number of pending cases. There were 50,473 cases pending on 1 October 2023. 38,286 fresh cases were filed between 1 October 2023 and 1 June 2024. Thus, the total number of cases pending was 89,029. As a consequence of the system put in place, as many as 69,898 cases were disposed of. The pendency came down to 19,131. What is even more remarkable is the reduction in cases that were pending for years.

Growing Trust and Teamwork

The impact of this initiative has been quite impressive. More and more litigants are coming forward for dispute resolution. While old cases are being resolved, a record number of new cases have been filed during the last four months. It is an indication of the trust of the people in the new regime.

Vamsi credits his entire team for this feat. “It was a collective effort. I want to thank all the members, from data entry operators to additional collectors.” He is humble enough not to take the credit himself. For him, it is a standard routine affair for any district collector.

The model put in place in Basti is a wonderful example of a “Nexus of Good”, as it can, and hopefully will, be replicated in other districts of the country. This will take care of a major issue of delays that besets our governance.

Views expressed are personal

STRATEGIC  
OUTLOOK



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS  
A RETIRED IPS  
OFFICER, ADVISER  
NATSTRAT, AND A  
FORMER NATIONAL  
SECURITY ADVISOR  
IN MAURITIUS

The current truce reflects a temporary pause shaped by compulsion, not consensus, with regional developments continuing to test its credibility and long-term viability

Imbroglia Without End

Pakistan’s mediation has raised expectations, but contradictions, mistrust, and shifting geopolitical realities suggest the US–Iran ceasefire remains fragile and unlikely to deliver lasting peace of mind

There is still considerable ambiguity in the Pakistan-brokered peace talks between Iran and the US, and in the absence of any clarity, news is trickling in that another round of peace talks is scheduled in Islamabad very shortly. Details of the outcome will be known much after this opinion piece falls into the hands of the readers. Meanwhile, Pakistan’s euphoria in “successfully” brokering a truce remains tentative and does not show any promise, at least for the near future.

Objectively speaking, Pakistan does not really deserve any credit for facilitating the talks, and it is by sheer default that it got an opportunity to host the truce negotiations in Islamabad, raising its wishful thinking as a seasoned negotiator. Its Foreign Office (FO) and diplomatic community are agog that it had, by one stroke, got the US and Iran on its side and has now emerged as a regional power among the Islamic world. Pakistan appears ecstatic over the overwhelming response it received, especially from countries like Saudi Arabia, Turkey, UAE, etc., which have been targeted by Iran in the ongoing military confrontation. There is also what seems to be a misplaced sense of satisfaction—a domestic perception that Pakistan successfully managed the deal, proving its credibility, balance, and strategic patience, “qualities” that Pakistan tried to demonstrate by enabling this deal.

Meanwhile, well-known Pakistani columnist Muhammad Amir Rana



The current truce reflects a temporary pause shaped by compulsion, not consensus

and other commentators, dwelling on Pakistan’s brokered talks, assess that there are now new opportunities between Iran and Pakistan to reinforce their bilateral ties. The prospects of rebuilding the level of trust that existed during the Shah’s era appear limited, especially in view of the hardline orientation of the current regime in Iran—this war, in fact, might have reinforced Tehran’s sense of strategic pride and made the country more hesitant to move closer to a state it has long regarded as an adversary. In fact, this view has shaped much of Iran’s geopolitical and geo-economic outlook. The implications of the war are significant. The regime in Iran has survived, but survival alone should not be mistaken for strength, as the country is now militarily stretched and faces political and economic constraints. Within Iran’s borders, a challenge has surfaced which is perhaps more complex than the one on the external front.

In another viewpoint given by veteran Pakistani diplomat Maleeha Lodhi, the ceasefire agreement came about when the two warring parties wanted an off-ramp from the conflict and stepped back from their maximalist positions. Iran had previously said it would not agree to a temporary ceasefire and insisted on a comprehensive settlement for a lasting end to the war. It also said it would not open the Strait of Hormuz in return for a ceasefire. However, it then agreed to a two-week truce and the opening of the strategic waterway to maritime traffic for the ceasefire’s duration. Pakistan’s role in shaping the two-phase peace plan was important in persuading both sides to the negotiating table. Yet, it did not seem to work. Within hours of the ceasefire announcement, challenges emerged. Israel launched its deadliest attacks yet on Lebanon. This prompted Iran to again

close the Strait of Hormuz, saying this was part of the ceasefire agreement with the US. However, Trump and Vice President Vance claimed Lebanon was not included in the ceasefire, thus contradicting the assertion by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif that it was. This underlined the difficulties of sustaining a delicate ceasefire. That appears even more likely after the inconclusive Islamabad talks. Frustrated by its failure to force Iran to surrender, Israel may try, as per Pakistani think tanks, to sabotage the resumption of the US–Iran dialogue. This is generally the perception among Pakistani strategists.

Maleeha Lodhi further opines that, given these conflicting proposals, it was unrealistic to expect that an agreement could be reached in no time. Diplomacy, according to her, after all is a process, not a one-day event. In the opening bid, it was not surprising that neither side budged from their posi-

tions. While both wanted de-escalation, they were not prepared at this juncture to retract from their principal demands. Statements by US and Iranian officials after the talks made this evident, each side declaring what it saw as the sticking points. But both kept open the possibility of continuing diplomatic options. The coming days, however, will show whether and when this might happen. A return to war is certainly not in the interest of either country. Judging by these estimates, it is highly improbable that the next round of talks is going to yield any tangible results. Hence, the imbroglia remains.

In the ongoing context, it appears relevant to quote what The Guardian wrote in its editorial: “This is a strategic defeat for the US that will resound for decades, and a clear sign of its systemic failures.” In a similar vein, The Economist said, “Donald Trump is the biggest loser” in a conflict that has revealed “the shallowness of his vision for a new way of wielding American power.” US credibility stands damaged in the region and its reputation battered across the world. Indeed, it seems the closing of an era of American dominance and hegemony in the Middle East, where its security umbrella also failed to protect its allies. This is, at least largely, what the Pakistani perception is, which continues to try and mediate the deal between the two warring countries amidst the unending imbroglia, with bleak prospects of a breakthrough.

Views expressed are personal



EU close to approving release of \$106 bn loan to Ukraine

**BRUSSELS:** European Union envoys gathered on Wednesday with most cautiously optimistic that a massive loan to help meet Ukraine's military and financial needs for the next two years is close to being approved after months of deadlock.

Meeting in Brussels, the envoys assessed whether Hungary might lift its veto on the 90 billion euro (\$106 billion) loan package, originally agreed in December, which Ukraine desperately needs to prop up its war-ravaged economy and help keep Russian forces at bay.

Hungary has insisted that it must start receiving supplies of Russian oil again via Ukraine before it will unblock the funds. AGENCIES

## Nepal Home Minister resigns amid questions over financial conduct

**KATHMANDU:** Nepal Home Minister Sudan Gurung on Wednesday tendered his resignation – little over three weeks after taking oath – after facing allegations related to his financial conduct while in office.

Gurung became talk of the town after he jailed former prime minister K P Oli and the then home minister Ramesh Lekhak within 24 hours after assuming his post.

The resignation by Gurung, who was appointed as Home Minister on March 27, comes amid growing criticisms over his alleged business links and shares' transactions with a controversial businessman.

Gurung wrote on his social media site that he has resigned from the post to ensure impartial investigation into matters relating to his financial conduct and to avoid the conflict of interest while in office.



Nepal Home Minister Sudan Gurung

“For me, ethics is greater than position, and there is no greater force than public trust. The ongoing Gen Z movement in the country, which is demanding good governance, transparency and accountability, has also conveyed this message—that public life must be clean and leadership must be accountable. “If anyone questions the government formed

on the blood and sacrifice of my 46 brothers and sisters, the answer to that is ethics,” Gurung wrote in a Facebook post. Gurung was active during September 2025's Gen Z movement.

Among the many other things, he was also seen distributing bottled water to the protesters in Maitighar Mandala and Naya Baneshwor, the main venue of the protest.

He also played a crucial role in inking a deal between former Kathmandu Mayor and rapper-turned-politician Prime Minister Balendra Shah 'Balen' and Ravi Lamichhane, a TV journalist-turned-politician, who is the president of the Ras-triya Swatantra Party (RSP).

According to Prime Minister Shah's secretariat, Gurung has handed over his resignation letter to the prime minister. AGENCIES

## AHEAD OF WASHINGTON TALKS Israel urges Lebanon to join forces against Hezbollah

**JERUSALEM:** Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar called on Lebanon to work with Israel to disarm the Iranian-backed militant group Hezbollah ahead of negotiations in Washington on Thursday.

The meeting follows a similar gathering last week in Washington, and is the first time in decades the two countries are speaking directly.

“We don't have any serious disagreements with Lebanon. There are a few minor border disputes that can be solved,” Saar said during Independence Day remarks to Israel's diplomatic corps.

“The obstacle to peace and normalisation between the countries is one: Hezbollah,” he said, adding that Lebanon could have “a future of sovereignty, independence and freedom from the Iranian occupation”.

Israel's military has currently established a buffer zone stretching around 10 km (6 miles) into southern Lebanon to remove the threat of short-range rockets and anti-tank missiles toward northern Israel.

Meanwhile, one person was killed in a drone strike on eastern Lebanon on Wednesday.

Lebanon's state-run National News Agency said the drone strike on the village of Jabbour also wounded two people.

The Israeli military denied that it had struck in that area.

Since a 10-day ceasefire went into effect Friday, there have been several Israeli strikes while Hezbollah claimed its first attack Tuesday.

French President Emmanuel Macron says a French peacekeeper wounded in an attack in Lebanon over the weekend has died of his wounds.

Macron posted on X that the soldier died in France on



Locals drive past the site of buildings destroyed in an Israeli airstrike, in southern Lebanon

AP/PTI

### Takeaways

- » One person was killed in a drone strike on eastern Lebanon
- » A French peacekeeper injured in an attack in Lebanon over the weekend has died of his wounds
- » Lebanon and Israel held their first direct talks in decades last week in Washington

Wednesday, a day after being transferred from Lebanon.

Another French peacekeeper was killed in the attack on Saturday, in which the force came under small arms fire in southern Lebanon. Macron blamed the attack on Hezbollah, which has denied being behind it.

Hezbollah began firing missiles into Israel in early March, just two days after the US and Israel launched the war on Iran. Israel had responded with heavy bombardment and a ground invasion.

The meeting at the Elysee presidential palace came after the UN peacekeeping force in southern Lebanon, known as UNIFIL, came under attack from small arms fire on Saturday, leaving one French peacekeeper dead and three others wounded, two of them seriously. Both Macron and the UNIFIL force have blamed Hezbollah, which has denied involvement.

Macron said France is ready

to maintain its military on the ground, alongside international partners, in a potential follow-up force that could take over from UNIFIL.

The peacekeeper mission's term expires at the end of the year, in line with a vote of the U.N. Security Council in August.

Earlier Tuesday, Salam attended a meeting of European Union foreign ministers

in Luxembourg focused on the Middle East. The 27-member bloc's policy toward Israel has divided the EU and stymied unified action.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun later proposed direct negotiations with Israel — the first in decades — in exchange for a halt in hostilities, an offer initially rejected. Momentum shifted after a US-Iran truce announcement and Pakistan-brokered talks between the two sides.

Lebanon and Israel held their first direct talks in decades last week in Washington, after more than a month of fighting between Israel and Hezbollah.

Iran has insisted any ceasefire agreement must extend to Lebanon and warned it would not reopen the strategic Strait of Hormuz otherwise.

The US announced a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah on Thursday, describing it as a result of Israel-Lebanon talks. AGENCIES

### ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

प्लॉट संख्या-01, सेक्टर-नॉलेज पार्क-4, ग्रेटर नोएडा सिटी, गौतमबुद्धनगर  
वेबसाइट: [www.greaternoidaauthority.in](http://www.greaternoidaauthority.in), ई-मेल: [authority@gnida.in](mailto:authority@gnida.in)

पत्रिका: स्वांगि/2026/793

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

दिनांक: 22.04.2026

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (स्वास्थ्य), ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नोएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-स्वांगि/2026/792, दिनांक 22.04.2026 के माध्यम से कार्य की ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा की समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट [www.gnida.up.gov.in](http://www.gnida.up.gov.in) पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइटों को देखते रहें।

| क्र. सं. | कार्य का नाम /वर्क सर्किल                                                                                                                                          | अनुमानित लागत |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------|
| 1.       | Comprehensive Operation and Maintenance Contract of 02 Nos. of Truck Mounted Mechanical Sweeping Machines including Mechanized Sweeping of Roads in Greater Noida. | ₹0 144.35 लाख |

उक्त कार्य की निविदा दिनांक 24.04.2026 से 21.05.2026 को 17:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। उक्त कार्य की ई-निविदा की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन बिड दिनांक 25.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी। उपरोक्त निविदा में प्रतिभाग करने वाली कर्मी / एजेंसियों की प्री-बिड मीटिंग (Pre-Bid Meeting) दिनांक 30.04.2026 को अपराह्न 04:00 बजे ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण कार्यालय, भूखण्ड सं-01, सेक्टर नॉलेजपार्क-4, ग्रेटर नोएडा के प्रशासनिक भवन में चतुर्थ तल पर आहूत की गयी है।

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (स्वास्थ्य)

Follow Us On / OfficialGNIDA

### DEPARTMENT OF SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY & TECHNICAL EDUCATION BIHAR COUNCIL ON SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

IGSC-PLANETARIUM, BAILEY ROAD, PATNA-800 001

NIT No.- 16/2026

TENDER NOTICE

(Through e-procurement only)

Bihar Council on Science and Technology, Patna on behalf of Department of Science, Technology and Technical Education (DSTTE), Government of Bihar invites online bids from eligible entities to rent out the Food Court facility to a Food Aggregator for operating and managing a multi-brand food court and allied food and beverage services at Dr. A. P. J. Abdul Kalam Science City, Patna, on e-procurement (eporc2) Portal.

Interested bidders may download detailed tender document containing eligibility criteria, other terms & Conditions from website [www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in](http://www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in) as per the following schedule:-

| SL | Information                                                    | Details                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. | RFP No. and Date of availability                               | NIT No. 16/2026<br>Available to download from 20/04/2026, 6:00 pm onwards till 12/05/2026, 3:00 pm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 2. | Last date for submission of written queries for clarifications | 26/04/2026, 5:00 PM, through Email To: <a href="mailto:pd@bctst.org.in">pd@bctst.org.in</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 3. | Date of pre-bid conference                                     | 27/04/2026, 11:30 AM<br>In offline mode at Bihar Council on Science and Technology, Patna, IGSC planetarium, Patna, 800001<br>Online Meeting Link- <a href="https://meet.google.com/rvf-qokb-jko">https://meet.google.com/rvf-qokb-jko</a>                                                                                              |
| 4. | Last date of submission of bid                                 | 12/05/2026, 3:00 PM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 5. | Opening of Technical Bids                                      | 12/05/2026, 4:00 PM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 6. | Opening of Financial Bids                                      | To be intimated                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 7. | Contact person                                                 | Project Director, Bihar Council on Science & Technology (BCST), IGSC Planetarium, Adalatganj, Patna-800001 Email id: <a href="mailto:pd@bctst.org.in">pd@bctst.org.in</a> , <a href="mailto:apjcitybi@bctst.org.in">apjcitybi@bctst.org.in</a> , Website- <a href="https://apjcitybi.bihar.gov.in/">https://apjcitybi.bihar.gov.in/</a> |

DSTTE, Patna, Bihar reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders in full or part without assigning any reason.

PR. No. 001536 (Sci.&Tech.) 2026-27 (Project Director)

This information is available on website [www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar](http://www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar) also

गर्भावस्था की पहली तिमाही में माँ की एच.आई.वी. और सिफिलिस की जाँच जरूर कराये।

### NORTHERN RAILWAY

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

| S. No. | Tender No. | Brief Description                         | Qty.       | Closing Date |
|--------|------------|-------------------------------------------|------------|--------------|
| 01     | 19251697C  | PANTO FOOT INSULATOR                      | 324 NOS    | 11.05.2026   |
| 02     | 07250349A  | OVER HAULING KIT FOR KES TYPE             | 658 SET    | 11.05.2026   |
| 03     | 12265005   | HEAVY DUTY PASSENGER ESCALATOR            | 16 NOS     | 11.05.2026   |
| 04     | 10260022   | SUPERIOR QUALITY PILLOW                   | 114966 NOS | 14.05.2026   |
| 05     | 08260001A  | SPARE PART OF AC ELECTRIC LIFTING BARRIER | 984 SET    | 15.05.2026   |
| 06     | 10265051   | MODERN BAG PACK                           | 7876 NOS   | 20.05.2026   |

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 05/2026-2027 Dated: 21.04.2026 1327/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

### PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Vivek @ Balle S/o Daulatram R/o H.No. 06, Vijay Nagar Colony, Harijan Wali Gali, Bawana, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 99/2012 U/s 385/506/507/34 IPC & 120B IPC at PS: Bawana, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vivek @ Balle** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vivek @ Balle** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vivek @ Balle** of FIR No. 99/2012 U/s 385/506/507/34 IPC & 120B IPC of PS: Bawana, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 02.06.2026.

By order  
**Bharti Beniwal**  
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05  
North, Room No.114, First Floor,  
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5255/ON/2026

### MP POORV KSHETRA VIDYUT VITARAN CO. LTD.

BLOCK NO-7, SHAKTI BHAWAN, RAMPUR, JABALPUR (M.P.)  
Tel No: 0761 2702473, Fax No.0761-2660048  
CIN: U40109MP20025GCO15120, e-mail: [eeppurez@yahoo.in](mailto:eeppurez@yahoo.in)  
Jabalpur, dtd:- 06.04.2026

### TENDER NOTICE

Online tender is invited for supply of following items from manufacturers only as per tender specifications. The Bids will be received online On the portal <https://mptenders.gov.in> up to date & time as per key dates. The tender will be opened in the other a undersigned as mentioned in tender time schedule (key dates) in presence of bidders duly authorized representative who may like to be present at the time of opening of tender:-

| Sr No | T.S. No. (For e-Tendering) DISCOM/ EZ/PUR | Name of Items         | APPROX. VALUE (Rs. in Lakhs) | TENDER FEE (in Rs.) | Due date of times of opening of Tender (*) |
|-------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 1     | TS-1675 (e-Tender 2026. PKVVC-497456-1)   | Stay Set (Painted)    | 167.56                       | 5900                | 28.04.2026                                 |
| 2     | TS-1677 (e-Tender 2026. PKVVC-497485-1)   | Stay Wire & G.I. Wire | 139.24                       | 5900                | 28.04.2026                                 |

\* For updated/extended due dates for opening of tender (EMD in Cover -1 & Techno-commercial bid in Cover-2) please refer to the online key dates.

SAVE ENERGY FOR BETTER TOMORROW CGM(S&P)

“बिजली संबंधी शिकायतों के निराकरण के लिए 1912 डायल करें”

### JHARKHAND URJA SANCHARAN NIGAM LIMITED

(CIN No.:U40108JH2013SGC001704)  
Regd. Office: 2nd Floor, JUSNL (SLDC) Building Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi - 834002 (E-mail: [ce@jusnl@gmail.com](mailto:ce@jusnl@gmail.com))

### e-TENDER NOTICE NIT No. -41/PR/JUSNL/ 2026-27

E-tender in two parts i.e. Technical (Part-I) and Financial (Part - II) is invited from reputed, capable, experienced and financially sound firm for the following works :-

| Name of work                                       | Design, Engineering, Supply of Materials/ Equipments, Erection, Testing and commissioning of 132 kV 3ph D/C Transmission line with Panther conductor and OPGW from 132/33 kV Gailkera GSS to 132/2x25 kV Gailkera RTSS along with 2 nos. 132 kV 3ph Line bay at GSS, Gailkera on turnkey basis. |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Estimated cost (Rs.)                               | Rs. 9,542,001.00 (including GST)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Earnest Money Deposit                              | Rs. 18,70,900.00 (On line mode)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Completion Period                                  | 09 (Nine) Months                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| e-Tender fee                                       | Rs. 10,000.00 + 18% (Online mode).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Start Date & Time of Download the Tender Documents | 27.04.2026 at 11:00 AM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Start Date and time of upload of BID               | 27.04.2026 at 11:00 AM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| End date and time of upload of BID                 | 18.05.2026 upto 04:00 PM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| BID Opening date for technical part                | 19.05.2026 at 04:00 PM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BID Opening date for price part                    | Will be communicated                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Procurement Officer and address for communication  | General Manager, C&M (NWBP), 2 <sup>nd</sup> Floor, JUSNL (SLDC) Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi – 834002                                                                                                                                                                               |

1. e-Tender document and BOQ including terms & conditions, tender specification can be downloaded from website <https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>. Any details required in this regard can also be had from the office of the undersigned (6202162568) during office hours.

2. The bids will be received through electronic tendering mode only.

3. No claim shall be entertained on account of disruption of internet services being used by bidders. Bidders are advised to upload their bids well in advance to avoid last minute technical snag.

सहित एवं राश्ट्रिय में ऊर्जा बचाव। कृपया अपनौशिकयों को 18003456570(कॉल सेंटर) पर दर्ज कराये।

Sd/-  
PR 378108 (Jharkhand Urja Sancharan Nigam Ltd)26-27-D General Manager, C&M (NWBP)

## Pope calls for justice, closing income gap in Equatorial Guinea Mass with presidential family

**MONGOMO:** Pope Leo XIV urged Equatorial Guinea on Wednesday to work for justice and to close the gap “between the privileged and the disadvantaged” as he opened a day drawing attention to the vast income inequalities and human rights abuses in the Central African country.

Leo began the day with Mass in Mongomo, an eastern city on the border with Gabon that has experienced major development since Equatorial Guinea's oil boom in the 1990s. President Teodoro Obiang Nguema Mbasogo, who has been accused of widespread corruption and authoritarianism in his four-decade



Pope Leo XIV, flanked by Equatorial Guinea's President Teodoro Obiang Nguema Mbasogo (right), being welcomed at Malabo International Airport in Malabo on Tuesday

AP/PTI

rule, comes from Mongomo and the city has benefited from government investment and infrastructure, even though no

official institutions are located here. While more than half of Equatorial Guinea's population lives in poverty, Mon-

gomo boasts opulent buildings, curated gardens behind gilt-tipped gates, an 18-hole golf course and is the starting point of the lone highway in the country, linking the city to Bata on the west coast.

Obiang and his wife were on hand for Leo's Mass, as was their son, Teodoro “Teddy” Nguema Obiang, the country's vice president who was convicted of embezzling millions of euros by a French court, which handed him a three-year suspended sentence, a 30 million euro (\$35.2 million) fine and ordered the seizure of his luxury homes and cars in France worth tens of millions of euros. AGENCIES

## ‘BRITAIN NEEDS TO EMBRACE THE USE OF AI’ Iran, Russia & China behind most major cyberattacks against UK: Cyber chief

**GLASGOW:** The most serious cyberattacks in the UK are now carried out by hostile nations including Russia, Iran and China, the head of the UK's National Cyber Security Centre said in a speech Wednesday.

Richard Horne, the head of the National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC) — part of the UK's signals intelligence agency GCHQ — warned that the UK is living through “the most seismic geopolitical shift in modern history”.

British businesses, he said, need to prepare themselves to defend against cyberattacks because the UK could be targeted “at scale,” if it became involved in an international conflict. In recent months, authorities in Sweden, Poland, Denmark and Norway have all warned that hackers linked to Russia have targeted their critical infrastructure including power plants and dams.

Horne said the NCSC currently handles around four “nationally significant” cyber incidents a week and while criminal activity, such as ransomware, remains the most common problem, the most serious threat comes from cyberattacks carried out



“RECENTLY, CRITICAL INFRA INCLUDING POWER PLANTS AND DAMS WERE TARGETED IN UK”

directly or indirectly by other states. Dan Jarvis, the UK security minister, said the NCSC handled more than 200 nationally significant incidents last year — more than double the year before. Jarvis and Horne spoke at the CyberUK conference in the Scottish city of Glasgow. In December, Blaise Metreweli, the head of Britain's Secret Intelligence Service, or MI6, said the world is more dangerous and contested now than it has been for decades and that the UK is operating in a space between peace and war. China's intelligence and

military agencies display an “eye-watering level of sophistication in their cyber operations,” while Iran is “almost certainly using cyber activity to support the repression of British individuals on our streets who are seen as a threat to the regime,” he said. Moscow, meanwhile, is using tactics and techniques honed during its war in Ukraine and is “moving them beyond the battlefield,” Horne said, pointing to “sustained Russian hybrid activity” targeting the UK and Europe.

Companies, he said, must learn how cyber operations have been used in conflict situations in order to boost their own resilience.

Hostile states, Jarvis said, know the most effective way to act is “not to confront us directly, but to quietly hollow us out,” by hacking logistics systems which move goods, for example, or compromising businesses.

He compared a cyberattack at Britain's biggest automaker Jaguar Land Rover to masked criminals turning up at car dealerships, breaking glass, smashing computers and stealing vehicles from the parking lot. AGENCIES



‘SHORT-TERM FLUCTUATIONS UNDER WATCH’

# RBI Guv Malhotra calls FDI outflows ‘cyclical in nature’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/NEW YORK: Short-term fluctuations, including net FDI outflows and exchange rate movements, are cyclical in nature and are being closely monitored, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said.

He was speaking at a round-table hosted by Consulate General of India in New York on Monday. A press release was issued the next day.

Malhotra highlighted the ongoing reforms to simplify regulatory frameworks, enhance ease of doing business, expand market access for foreign investors, and further integrate onshore and offshore markets.

The round-table was attended by over 100 representatives from financial institutions, investment firms and policy circles, including participants from banks, asset man-



Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra speaks during an interaction event at the Consulate General of India, in New York

agement firms, family offices, capital management firms, institutional investors, wealth managers, and other industry professionals.

During the session, RBI Chief General Manager Dimple Bhandia gave a presentation, highlighting the country's

strong macroeconomic fundamentals, resilient financial sector, and consistent policy framework.

It emphasized India's position as the fastest-growing major economy and its trajectory to become the third-largest economy globally in the

**INSIGHT**

» He was speaking at a round-table hosted by Consulate General of India in New York

» Malhotra highlighted the ongoing reforms to simplify regulatory frameworks, enhance ease of doing business, expand market access for foreign investors, and further integrate onshore and offshore markets

coming years.

The discussion highlighted key indicators such as low inflation within the target range, a manageable current account deficit of around 1.1 per cent of GDP, robust foreign exchange reserves of USD 700 billion, the release added. WITH AGENCIES INPUTS

## IT ministry notifies online gaming rules

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) on Wednesday notified the much-awaited rules providing the procedural framework to operationalise the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, which will also facilitate the creation of an online gaming authority.

Most online games - if they are not real money games, which are already and explicitly banned under the provisions - will not mandatorily need to be registered or determined, IT Secretary S Krishnan said.

Oversight will be triggered only in certain circumstances.

Esports, however, will require mandatory registration as specified in the parent Act.

"...We wanted to, as far as possible, keep this entire thing as regulation-light as possible.

Most games, which are not money games, should be able to operate with no obligation to necessarily either be determined or registered. So that entire process is optional," he said. "We are not obligating anybody to apply to determine whether it is an online money game, or online social game, or esports."

That said, such 'determination' will be triggered in three situations. The first trigger is where it is done suo moto by the authority, and the second is where it involves esports games. "And third, the central government may notify any specific category of social games, which, as of now, we have not notified anything specifically."

The act itself bans online real money gaming. MPOST

## Stock markets snap 3-day rally

Sensex falls 757 pts dragged by IT shares, jump in oil prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled nearly 1 per cent on Wednesday, snapping a three-day gaining streak due to heavy selling in IT stocks and an uptick in crude oil prices.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 756.84 points or 0.95 per cent to settle at 78,516.49. During the day, it slumped 831.03 points or 1.04 per cent to 78,442.30.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 198.50 points or 0.81 per cent to end at 24,378.10.

Foreign fund outflows and fears of prolonged instability in West Asia also dented market sentiment.

Among 30-Sensex firms, HCL Tech tumbled the most by 10.85 per cent after its March quarter earnings failed to cheer



FILE PIC

investors. HCL Tech reported a 4.20 per cent on-year rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 4,488 crore for the March quarter, even as the management flagged a highly volatile demand environment shadowed by tariffs and softened discretionary spends, giving a FY27 growth guidance of 1-4 per cent.

Infosys, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Consultancy Services, Tech Mahindra and ICICI Bank were also among the major laggards. Hindustan

OPEN FOR PUBLIC COMMENTS TILL MAY 20

## Centre overhauls six-decade old Sugarcane Control Order

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has proposed replacing the 1966 Sugarcane Control Order with a sweeping new regulatory framework that brings ethanol production, digital compliance, and a formal factory approval regime under a single law for the first time, seeking public comments by May 20.

The Union Food Ministry's draft Sugarcane (Control) Order 2026 keeps the skeleton of the old law intact - Fair and Remunerative Price rules, cane movement controls, 14-day payment deadline, and 15 per cent annual interest on delayed payments - but brings in an entirely new architecture suited to an industry that has changed beyond recognition since the Nehru era.

The most significant departure from 1966 is the explicit integration of ethanol into the sugarcane regulatory framework. The draft expands the definition of a sugar factory to



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

cover ethanol production from sugarcane juice, syrup, sugar, and molasses. A concrete conversion formula has been introduced: 600 litres of ethanol will be treated as equivalent to one tonne of sugar for production calculation purposes.

Ethanol-only units that do not crush cane on their own premises are exempted from the performance bank guarantee requirement - a deliberate policy nudge to grow standalone ethanol capacity without loosening controls on integrated sugar-cum-ethanol mills. Clauses 6A through 6G introduce what the old order

never had: a formal IEM-based approval process for new factories, minimum distance rules, performance bank guarantees raised to Rs 2 crore, and hard deadlines for both "effective steps" and commercial production.

The draft also creates, for the first time, a factory lifecycle regime - covering transfer restrictions before commercial production, reinstatement of derecognised projects, and automatic derecognition if a factory remains closed for seven consecutive sugar seasons.

The by-product explanation is also tightened to recognize imputed value from value-added uses such as ethanol, bio-fertilizer, and power generation, while excluding bagasse used only for boiler operation in the main sugar factory.

Each factory will be assigned a plant name and plant code for tracking, and reporting can now be submitted digitally.

## Rupee falls 34 paise against USD

MUMBAI: Falling for the third straight session, the rupee declined 34 paise to close at 93.78 against the US dollar on Wednesday as uncertainty over US-Iran peace talks eroded hopes of easing West Asia tensions and set crude oil prices on fire.

Intense selling in domestic equity markets and sustained outflow of foreign capital also weighed on the domestic currency, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 93.69 and touched an intraday low of 93.87 against the greenback during the session.

The domestic unit finally ended the session at 93.78 against the dollar, registering a loss of 34 paise from the previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee plunged 28 paise to settle at 93.44 against the US dollar, a day after losing 25 paise on Monday. The currency had gained 47 paise in the preceding two sessions.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, went down 0.07 per cent to 98.15.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 1.29 per cent higher at USD 99.75 per barrel in futures trade.

Analysts said the crude prices climbed after two ships came under attack in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday, complicating efforts to end the war.

The fresh attacks came days after the US seized an Iranian container ship. MPOST

## India's textile exports grow 2.1% in 2025-26

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's textile exports, including those of handicrafts, increased by 2.1 per cent to Rs 3.16 lakh crore in the financial year ended March 2026 from Rs 3.09 lakh crore a year ago, the Textile ministry said on Wednesday.

The growth comes despite the sector facing steep tariffs imposed by the US, its largest export destination, for most of the financial year.

The reciprocal tariff regime began with 10 per cent on April 2, 2025 and was rapidly escalated. Rates for India rose to 25 per cent by August 7, 2025 and to 50 per cent by August 28, remaining at that level until early February 2026.

Following the US Supreme Court's decision against the sweeping tariffs imposed by President Donald Trump on a number of countries, the Trump administration imposed a 10 per cent tariff on all countries from February 24 for 150 days.

This performance reflects steady global demand for Indian textile products and the continued competitiveness of the sector across major product categories, the textile ministry stated.

Export growth was registered in more than 120 destinations during April 2025 to February 2026 over the corresponding period of the previous year, indicating broad-based geographical expansion in India's textile export basket.

A notable growth has been observed in key markets such as the UAE (22.3 pc), UK (7.8 pc), Germany (9.9 pc), Spain (15.5 pc), Japan (20.6 pc),

## Atal Pension Yojana surpasses 9 cr subscribers

NEW DELHI: Atal Pension Yojana (APY), a flagship social security scheme of the government, administered by the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA), has achieved a total gross enrolment of 9 crore subscribers.

The scheme's gross enrolments during the financial year 2025-26 have exceeded 1.35 crore subscribers, marking the highest-ever enrolments recorded in a single financial year since the scheme's inception.

Launched on May 9, 2015, with the vision of establishing a universal social security system for all Indians, APY is a voluntary, contributory pension scheme primarily focused on the poor, the underprivileged, and workers in the unorganized sector, PFRDA said.

The scheme is open to all Indian citizens between the ages of 18 and 40 years, except those who have been income tax payers, it added. MPOST



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Egypt (38.3 pc), Nigeria (21.4 pc), Senegal (54.4 pc), and Sudan (205.6 pc), etc.

Among the major segments, ready-made garments (RMG) of all textiles remained the largest contributor to textile exports, increasing from Rs 1.35 lakh crore to Rs 1.39 lakh crore, up 2.9 per cent year on year.

Shipments of cotton yarn, fabrics, made-ups and handloom products remained flat, recording 0.4 per cent growth at Rs 1.02 lakh crore in FY 2025-26.

Man-made yarn, fabrics and made-ups posted a stronger growth of 3.6 per cent, with exports increasing from Rs 41,196 crore in the 2024-25 fiscal to 42,687.8 crore during 2025-26.

Among value-added segments, handicrafts, excluding handmade carpets, recorded the highest growth among major categories, rising by 6.1 per cent from Rs 14,945.5 crore in FY25 to Rs 15,855.1 crore during FY26.

The government has continued to support the sector through key export facilitation and remission measures, including the extension of the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCCTL) Scheme and the RoDTEP Scheme beyond March 2026.

## ITC scales CSR impact with 'multi-stakeholder' partnerships

NEW DELHI: ITC Limited is strengthening its corporate social responsibility initiatives through a partnership-driven approach, building a network of over 200 stakeholders across public and private sectors. Under its Public-Private-People Partnership (4P) strategy, the company has forged more than 98 public-private partnerships and 25 knowledge collaborations, working with over 110 implementing agencies.

ITC's social investment programmes span 24 states and over 300 districts, addressing key areas such as climate change adaptation, water security, natural resource management and circularity. The company acts as a facilitator, overseeing programme design, funding, governance, and impact assessment while ensuring community participation.

More than 29,700 grassroots institutions, including farmer groups, self-help groups and local committees, are actively involved in execution. MPOST

## India likely to breach budgeted fiscal deficit target for FY27

NEW DELHI: India's fiscal deficit is likely to breach the budgeted target for current fiscal and hit 4.5 per cent of GDP as the government's policy response to the West Asia conflict could strain public finances, research firm BMI said on Wednesday.

The government in 2026-27 Budget had projected a 4.3 per cent fiscal deficit, a tad lower than 4.4 per cent as per revised estimates for 2025-26.

BMI also expects the government to introduce policies to redirect critical inputs to key industries, restrain business costs and improve financial support for firms.

BMI said it also expects the government to consider restrictions on exports of scarce inputs such as helium and sulphur -- used for producing semiconductor chips.

It said that since sulphur is also an important ingredient for making fertilisers, the government will strive to minimise disruptions to the agriculture sector, which employs 43 per cent of India's workforce.

The government will seek to restrain cost increases for businesses affected by Strait of Hormuz's closure. To this end, the central government has established a Rs 1 lakh crore Economic Stabilisation Fund.

BMI estimates this will contribute 0.1 per cent of GDP to fiscal expenditure in 2026-27.

Strait of Hormuz is a key shipping lane through which about 20 per cent of the world's natural gas and crude oil transits.

Iran's grip on the strait has pushed oil prices sharply higher. Brent crude, the international benchmark, was trading close to USD 95 per barrel on Tuesday, up more than 30 per cent since February 28, the day Israel and the US launched strikes on Iran, triggering the war. AGENCIES

## NSE says power market coupling to 'cut costs' & 'improve efficiency'

MUMBAI: National Stock Exchange of India Limited has welcomed the draft amendments proposed by the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission for introducing market coupling in India's power sector, calling it a major step towards improving transparency and efficiency.

The Power Market (Draft Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026 propose that Grid India will act as the Market Coupling Operator, aggregating bids from all three spot power exchanges and determining a single market-clearing price. This unified pricing mechanism is expected to ensure consistent price discovery across exchanges and align with the "One Nation, One Grid, One Price" principle.

According to NSE, the move will address current disparities in pricing methodologies. At present, differences between volume-weighted average pricing—used in NSE's electricity futures settlement—and simple average pricing used by some exchanges have led to significant price gaps. As of

### The move will address current disparities in pricing methodologies

April 2026, this gap stood at around Rs 600-700 per MWh, increasing procurement costs for discoms.

The exchange estimates that such discrepancies could result in additional monthly costs of nearly Rs 70 crore for distribution companies, translating into an annual impact of about Rs 840 crore. NSE noted that since the launch of electricity futures in July 2025, spot power prices have declined by around 14 per cent, indicating improved market efficiency. It added that adopting globally aligned, volume-weighted pricing under market coupling would further deepen both spot and derivatives markets.

NSE MD & CEO Ashishkumar Chauhan said the reform would enhance price discovery, boost investor confidence and support greater investments in the power sector. MPOST

## West Asia crisis could drive up costs for products like clothes and crayons

Petrochemicals derived from oil, natural gas go into making over 6K products

NEW YORK: It might be hard to imagine the Iran war weighing on stuffed toys with names like Snuggly Glove, Bizzikins and Wobbles, but even plush playthings are not immune when oil shipments from the Middle East are constrained.

Like many soft toys, the creatures developed by a manufacturer in Fort Lauderdale, Florida, are made with polyester and acrylic, synthetic fibres derived from petroleum. Three weeks after the war started, suppliers in China notified Aleni Brands that getting the materials already was costing them 10 per cent to 15 per cent more, CEO Ricardo Venegas said.

"I think this situation demonstrates how much oil permeates throughout our system, and we can't get away from it," said Venegas, who founded Aleni Brands last year and is in the process of adding product lines. "Who would have thought that the price of a toy would have a direct relationship with oil?"

It's not just toys. Petrochemicals derived from oil



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

and natural gas go into making more than 6,000 consumer products, according to the US Department of Energy. Computer keyboards, lipstick, tennis rackets, pajamas, soft contact lenses, detergent, chewing gum, shoes, crayons, shaving cream, pillows, aspirin, dentures, tape, umbrellas and nylon guitar strings are just a few of them.

So far, the war's most tangible and immediate effect for many people outside the conflict zone has been spiking gasoline prices. Travellers also are seeing higher airfares and flight fees as airlines respond to the rising cost of jet fuel. Consumers may find themselves paying

**HIGHLIGHTS**

» The war's immediate effect for many people outside the conflict zone has been spiking gasoline prices

» Travellers are also seeing higher airfares and flight fees

more for food, furniture or any of the myriad of goods transported by trucks that run on diesel. But crude oil isn't just refined as fuel. It gets turned into chemicals, waxes, oils and other mixtures that appear in a vast array of everyday items, including most made with plastic and rubber. Petroleum derivatives also are used in a lot of packaging. With disruptions to global oil supplies now in their eighth week, higher production costs also could make things more expensive for shoppers, according to trade groups and some companies.

While 85 per cent of global oil consumption is in the form

of fuel, the rest goes into a wide range of consumer products, according to Gernot Wagner, a climate economist at Columbia University's School of Business.

Crude oil is mostly a complex mixture of hydrocarbons, which are compounds made of carbon and hydrogen atoms. Refineries and chemical plants separate and break them down to convert them into smaller chemical building blocks known as petrochemicals.

Six petrochemicals — ethylene, propylene, butylene, benzene, toluene and xylenes — are the major foundations of plastics and synthetic materials like nylon and polyesters, which manufacturers in turn use to design and deliver products.

More from the Department of Energy: Automobile parts, ballpoint pens, curtains, dice, eyeglasses, fertilizer, golf balls, hearing aids, insect repellent, kayaks, luggage, mops and nail polish. Materials account for a big share of production costs for many manufacturers, including those that supply carpets, clothing and tires. AGENCIES



# Giant fall for Lucknow

Embarrassing Super Giants undo Shami's effort to lose by 40 runs

LUCKNOW: Lucknow Super Giants batters, led by their mercurial skipper Rishabh Pant, let Mohammed Shami's brilliant bowling effort go down the drain with an embarrassing 40-run defeat at the hands of an equally profligate Rajasthan Royals in an IPL match here on Wednesday.

Chasing a target of 160, LSG huffed and puffed before being shot out for 119 in 18 overs after the slide started with their skipper Pant playing the most ugly sweep-cum-hoick to let the momentum slip after Shami, along with Mohsin Khan and Prince Yadav, had set up the platform for the hosts.

The decision to use a player like Himmat Singh as 'Impact Sub' will be questioned for the longest time as the player in nearly a decade of domestic cricket never won a SMAT game for Delhi with a career strike rate of 135 and less than a six per game. The win took Royals to the second spot with 10 points from seven games despite a shoddy batting effort.

Royals would be indebted to their 'OG' Ravindra Jadeja (43 no off 29 balls and 1/29) whose all-round effort went a long way in securing the win. His partnership with Shubham Dubey got them some kind of a total and then with the ball, he



Rajasthan Royals' Jofra Archer was their most successful bowler with figures of 3/20

PTI

flung the data analysts' match-up card to remove Nicholas Pooran. While Royals' batting has been inconsistent this season, the bowlers have been on the money as Rishabh Pant was dismissed by Nandre Burger (2/27), and Jofra Archer (3/20) accounted for Aiden Markram with a rising delivery. This was after Ayush Badoni was unfortunately run-out.

Mitchell Marsh (55 off 41 balls) held the innings together even as likes of Nicholas Pooran and Himmat Singh

went back playing some irresponsible shots. It was left to Mukul Choudhary, who still is a work in progress and haven't yet learnt how to tackle bouncers that grip off the surface.

Earlier, Shami delivered a couple of beauties while Mohsin snuffed out teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to restrict Royals to a meagre 159 for 6 after opting to bowl.

This is the third time in three games that Royals' top order has imploded and things have spiralled southwards for

the franchise. The experience and class of Shami (2/30 in 4 overs) the Test bowler stood apart while the lanky Mohsin (2/17 in 4 overs) was extremely disciplined, getting the ball to rear up and seam at the same time from awkward lengths.

The duo between them removed the four best batters of RR -- Shami getting rid of Yas-hasvi Jaiswal (22) and Dhruv Jurel (0) off successive deliveries and Mohsin removing Sooryavanshi (8 off 11 balls) and Shimron Hetmyer. AGENCIES

## Rohit, Dhoni perform bat at nets

NEW DELHI: Rohit Sharma and MS Dhoni batted in tandem in the nets session here on Wednesday, even as they are yet to be officially cleared for availability in the Indian Premier League clash between Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings on Thursday.

It remains to be seen if two main protagonists of the famed MI-CSK rivalry are available for another bout.

Rohit, who featured in the first four matches for MI, had walked off the pitch during the contest against Royal Challengers Bengaluru here 10 days ago with a hamstring injury and has been on a comeback trail since.

On the other hand, Dhoni is yet to take the field in this IPL as he has been nursing a calf strain which he picked up right before the tournament got underway late last month. AGENCIES

MUMBAI: Struggling former champions Mumbai Indians and Chennai Super Kings will be eyeing consistency as they await the return of their former captains Rohit Sharma and MS Dhoni, respectively, when they face off in the Indian Premier League here on Thursday.

Rohit (hamstring) and Dhoni (calf strain) are on the comeback trail, but it remains to be seen whether either will take the field at Wankhede Stadium for what has historically been an iconic IPL clash.

Rohit missed training during the optional session on Tuesday, while Dhoni, yet to feature in this IPL, went through his drills, hinting at a possible comeback as an Impact Substitute.

However, the subplot goes beyond the two Indian stalwarts, with both teams -- who share 10 IPL titles between them -- still battling multiple issues on several fronts.

CSK began the tournament in search of form and the right combination, as most teams do, and just as they appeared to be settling, a hamstring injury to local talent Ayush Mhatre, who had scored 201 runs, dealt a major blow.

Once again, CSK find themselves back at the drawing board, looking to fill the gap



MS Dhoni is yet to feature for CSK

PTI

## CSK will be keen to see their batters fire collectively

in their batting reserves, with Gujarat wicketkeeper-batter Urvil Patel among the options.

CSK will be keen to see their batters fire collectively after a disappointing loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad, a match they should have closed out comfortably while chasing 130 off 90 balls with eight wickets in hand, but a lack of initiative from the middle order allowed SRH to turn the tide in their favour. While Sarfaraz has been consistent with 147 runs, he is yet to convert starts

into a big innings despite holding a key batting role, especially with skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad enduring a disappointing campaign with just 82 runs.

A lot will similarly ride on Sanju Samson (192 runs) as well, given that the India wicketkeeper-batter returns to the venue of his T20 World Cup semifinal heroics.

CSK will also be aiming to snap their two match losing streak, banking on their strong recent record against MI, having won four of the last five encounters. With both teams on four points each, only net run rate separates seventh placed MI (0.067) and eighth placed CSK (-0.780), as in-form sides have pulled ahead with eight or more points. AGENCIES

## Chelsea lose to Brighton; Real get back on track

LONDON: Chelsea's season slumped deeper into crisis after a 3-0 defeat to Brighton on Tuesday left their hopes of Champions League qualification hanging by a thread.

The result leaves Chelsea seventh in the Premier League and seven points adrift of fifth place Liverpool having played a game more.

The top five qualify for the Champions League, but with just four more rounds of the season to go, Chelsea is on the verge of being cut adrift.

Goals from Ferdi Kadioglu, Jack Hinshelwood and Danny Welbeck at the AMEX Stadium did not reflect Brighton's dominance on the night. Victory saw it leapfrog Chelsea and move up to sixth in the standings and boosted its own pursuit of European soccer next season.

Meanwhile, Kylian Mbappé and Vinicius Júnior each scored as Real Madrid ended a four-game winless streak by defeating Alaves 2-1 on Tuesday to move closer to Spanish league leader Barcelona. AGENCIES

## 'Special talent' Abhishek leaves Pujara in awe

HYDERABAD: Former India cricketer Cheteshwar Pujara has hailed Abhishek Sharma as a special talent with class written all over, after the Sunrisers Hyderabad opener tore into the Delhi Capitals attack in an IPL match, powering a dominant, one-sided win.

Abhishek played a blistering, unbeaten knock, hammering 135 off just 68 balls to completely dismantle the bowling attack as SRH scored 242/2 and won the contest by 47 runs.

"Abhishek Sharma played a brilliant knock to score his second IPL hundred and his first this season. He makes cen-



turies look easy," Pujara told JioHotstar.

"His runs are crucial for SRH because they often lead

to wins. He is a special talent. When he performs like this, his class is there for everyone to see. Very few batters have the talent and class that Abhishek Sharma has," he added.

Abhishek, the world No. 1 T20I batter, was in full flow on Tuesday, smashing 10 sixes and as many fours in a one-sided demolition job.

Abhishek also had a slice of luck on his side, with a fumble behind the stumps by KL Rahul handing him a lifeline when he was on 50.

For former India spinner Harbhajan Singh, that was the game's turning point. AGENCIES

## Girls' State Gatka C'ship in Kotkapura from May 1

CHANDIGARH: The Gatka Association of Punjab, in collaboration with the Gatka Association District Faridkot, will host the 12th State Gatka Championship 2026 for girls at Baba Farid Gurukul College, Kotkapura, from May 1 to 3.

Advocate Harjeet Singh Grewal, President of the National Gatka Association of India, said the three-day event will bring together young exponents of the traditional Sikh martial art from across Punjab, promising a spirited display of skill, discipline and

heritage.

Teams from all districts will report on May 1, with competitions beginning at 9 am on May 2. The championship will conclude on May 3 with a closing ceremony attended by prominent dignitaries.

Bangladesh have won the last two editions, in 2022 and 2024.

Adding further vice president of Gatka Association of Punjab, Sarbjit Singh said the event would feature girls' teams competing across five age categories. MPPOST

## Leisure



## 'Now I really value the chill'

Anne Hathaway opened up about being in her 40s

Even as Anne Hathaway gears up for the release of 'The Devil Wears Prada 2' alongside Meryl Streep and Emily Blunt, she has been named People magazine's 'World's Most Beautiful Star 2026', further cementing her enduring presence in popular culture. On the occasion, Anne reflected on broader themes such as beauty, ageing and self-awareness.

In a chat with 'People' magazine, Anne Hathaway was asked how she defines beauty. She responded, "A filmmaker once told me this: 'Beauty can contain within its ugliness as long as it contains truth'. So, for me, beauty always falls along those lines."

When asked about beauty secrets she has learned over the years, she said, "I like all the massages. I love a Georgia Louise sculpting facial. And just understand your lighting, like that's the No. 1 thing because all of those things will not make a difference if you don't know how to



She has been named People magazine's 'World's Most Beautiful Star 2026'

find your light. Bad lighting is so mean and cruel and as you age, you need lighting that's a little bit more intelligent. So be aware of lighting."

She further shared advice

on presence and self-awareness, "And somebody told me that, at a certain point, especially if you're a naturally expressive person, which I am, you have to be aware that what feels normal to you is going to look exaggerated on a red carpet. And if people are taking photos, you might not be happy with the photos. So just be aware of your calmness. Be aware of your stillness."

Speaking about ageing and her 40s, Anne said, "You have to be more serious about how you take care of yourself. I just think that when you're in your 40s, you've had the opportunity to see how certain decisions bore fruit over time. And so, you can assess if you want to continue making those decisions or if you want to make new ones."

Over the years, Anne Hathaway has received major honours including an Academy Award, a BAFTA, a Golden Globe and a Primetime Emmy Award. Beyond 'The Devil Wears Prada 2', she is set to appear in Christopher Nolan's upcoming film 'Odyssey'. AGENCIES

## Here's why Boman is proud of Riteish

OUR CORRESPONDENT

At a recent event in Mumbai, the much-anticipated trailer of Riteish Deshmukh's directorial 'Raja Shivaji' was unveiled. And now, Boman Irani opened up about working with the actor-director with whom he had shared screen space in several films like the 'Housefull' franchise and 'Total Dhamaal'. Staying true to his signature style, Irani had the audience in splits while also sharing heartfelt admiration for his co-star-turned-director.

Recounting how he came on board the

He went on to describe his first day on set, revealing Riteish's rather unusual instruction: no makeup

film, Irani joked, "I didn't even say yes to this film... I wasn't even asked! I was just told, 'What are you doing on the 30th? I'll send you the address.'"

He went on to describe his first day on set, revealing Riteish's rather unusual instruction: no makeup. "He said if I wore

makeup, I'd look too young. He wanted me to look like an actual old man for my role as a Baba," Irani laughed.

Adding a dose of affection to the humour, he shared, "I love him like my own son, though he speaks to me as if I'm his!" Beyond the laughter, Irani expressed deep admiration for Riteish's vision and the scale of Raja Shivaji. Calling the film a 'spectacle', he praised the detailing in every frame and the sheer ambition of the project. "I made a small film with great difficulty and then I see this every shot, every exchange; it's incredible. I feel so proud of you," he said.



## Alemay Fernandez leads an All-Star Quartet for Int'l Jazz Day

She is a veteran performer in the Asian jazz scene

JAI TALWAR

In November 2011, legendary jazz pianist and composer Herbie Hancock and UNESCO officially named April 30 as International Jazz Day to highlight jazz and its diplomatic role of uniting people in all corners of the globe. Each year on April 30, this international art form is recognised for promoting peace, dialogue among cultures, diversity and respect for human rights and human dignity and promoting freedom of expression. NCPA has been hosting International Jazz Day for over a decade and this year, they are presenting the talented jazz vocalist Alemay Fernandez from Singapore.

Alemay is a veteran performer in the Asian jazz scene. In her 25-year career, she has performed with numerous illustrious musicians, including Ray Parker Jr, Nat Adderley Jr, Janis Siegel of 'Manhattan Transfer' and Lauren Kinhan of the 'New York Voices'. She has the distinction of being the only Asian singer to have performed with some of the top jazz orchestras in the world, such as Wynton Marsalis, Count Basie, Duke Ellington Orchestras and the Dizzy Gillespie All-Stars. She has also been the entertainment of choice for visiting celebrities and world leaders over the years, including



PIC/THAILAND INTERNATIONAL JAZZ CONFERENCE

In her 25-year career, she has performed with numerous illustrious musicians

Kevin Spacey, Ethan Hawke, Serena Williams and former US President Barack Obama.

Jazz lovers can expect a high-energy performance with powerhouse vocals as she will be supported by Sharik Hassan on piano, who has played with Wayne Shorter and Joe Lovano; Edward Livingston, who's played bass for Elvin Jones and the Marsalis Family and drummer Ben Scholz, who has kept time for Roy Hargrove and Buddy Guy.



PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

**See Section 84 BNSS**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Amit, S/o: Anil Kumar Prasad R/o: Kh No.: 292, G. No. 9, D Block, Gurunanak Dev Colony Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 960/2025, Dt. 03.12.25 U/S: 376 IPC / 65(1) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, 9 Child Maariage Act & 6/21 POCOso Act, PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Amit**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Amit**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Amit**, of **FIR No. 960/2025, Dt. 03.12.25 U/S: 376 IPC / 65(1) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, 9 Child Maariage Act & 6/21 POCOso Act, PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.05.2026**.

By Order  
Sh. Amit Sahrawat  
Additional Session Judge-01 (POCSO)  
(North Distt.), Room No. 306, Third Floor,  
District Court Rohini, Delhi

DP/5260/NW/2026  
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

**See Section 82 Cr.P.C.**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Gori Shanker, Director of Dev Constech Pvt. Ltd., R/o: Plot No-313, Kakrola Housing Complex Near Allahabad Park, Metro Pillar-789, Kakrola Mod, New Delhi-110059** also **R/o: H.No-202, 1<sup>st</sup> Floor, Kakrola Housing Complex Main Market Near Mahila Park new Delhi-110078** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC NI Act.: 2251/2023, U/s: 138/142 NI Act, P.S. Anand Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Gori Shanker** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Gori Shanker** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Gori Shanker of P.S. Anand Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.07.2026**.

By Order  
Sh. Rahul Saini  
JMFC-08, Room No. G-06,  
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DPI/4876/SHD/2026

**NORTHERN RAILWAY**  
**OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE**

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

|                                                                                    |                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Name of work</b>                                                                | Repair to stabling line No- 8 & 9 and 17 & 18 in the section of SSE/W/NDLS/Line under ADEN/NDLS.                     |
| <b>Approx cost of work</b>                                                         | ₹ 3,04,02,879.63/- (Rupees Three Crore Four Lakh Two Thousand Eight Hundred Seventy Nine and Sixty Three Paise Only) |
| <b>Earnest Money to be deposited</b>                                               | (Only)<br>₹ 6,08,100.00/- (Rupees Six Lakh Eight Thousand One Hundred and Eight Paise Only)                          |
| <b>Cost of tender document</b>                                                     | [Rs. 0.00/-]                                                                                                         |
| <b>Date &amp; Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender.</b>          | 14.05.2026 @15:00 Hrs.                                                                                               |
| <b>Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen.</b> | www.ireps.gov.in                                                                                                     |

\*The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) for participating in the e-tender system. \*For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. \*No manual offers are acceptable. \*Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No. 128-W/280/e Tender Notice/NIT/06/2026-27/W-3      Dated: 21.04.2026

**SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE**      1334/2026

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
**CORRIGENDUM - 01**

Corrigendum against Tender Notice No. 10/2026 dt. 07.04.2026 (Tender No. 19265740).

In reference to above tender notice, following corrigendum is being issued:-

| Field Name                 | Existing Value | Modified Value     |
|----------------------------|----------------|--------------------|
| Tender opening date        | 30.04.2026     | 12.05.2026         |
| Attachment                 |                | As per Corrigendum |
| Delivery period            |                |                    |
| Details of Scope of supply |                |                    |

For details, please check [ireps.gov.in](http://ireps.gov.in)      775/26 (A)

North central railways      @CPRONCR

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
**E-TENDER NOTICE**  
**STORES DEPARTMENT**

PAC TENDER Batch No- 01/2026 Date. 21/04/2026

E-Tender Notice for supply of materials "Participation in through" Web Portal of IREPS - [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in). Offers are invited for supply of the following material. The closing time for the tender is at 11:30 Hrs. 1. Tender No : 30265046 . 2. Short Description of item: MDL 69240IC 1AA 4101-ICP unit of VCU as per M/s- BHEL Material Code No. ED69240IC1AA of M/s BHEL make Propulsion system or Latest. 3. Quantity : 03 NOS. 4. Publishing Date & Time: 20 April 2026 15:42 Hrs. 5. Tender Closing Date & Time : 25 MAY. 2026 11:30 Hrs. Participants are required to submit their offer only on-line through the web Portal of IREPS-[www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in) before the closing date and time. Other details regarding Consignee and detailed description of stores are available in tender document in tender notice on the above portal.

Asstt. Materials Manager (TRS)  
E.C. Railway, Gomoh  
PR/0105/GMO CSD/STORE/7126-27/32

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
Open Tender No.: JHS-RCNK-M-TR-26-27-06

**E-TENDER NOTICE**

E-tenders are invited from experienced and interested contractors by Chief Workshop Manager, Rail Coach Naveenikaran karkhana, Jhansi on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work.

**Name of Work:** "Provision of SS metal trough below RMPU in place of FRP trough".

**Cost of work :** Rs. 2,85,29,910.00/-(Including 18% GST) **Bid Security :** Rs. 5,70,600.00/-

**Time of completion : Twenty-Four Months / Online tender closing date and time : 12.05.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.**

Detailed information about tender and tender format is available at website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in)      867/26 (D)

North central railways      www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in      @CPRONCR

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Virendra @ Banti S/o Kunwar Pal R/o: 1074, G-Block, Jhuggi Jahangir Puri, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 20/2026, U/S 304(2)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Virendra @ Banti** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Virendra @ Banti** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Virendra @ Banti** the said accused of **FIR No. 20/2026, U/S 304(2)/317(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.05.2026**.

By Order  
Sh. Rangat Ghirra,  
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04,  
Central Distt., Room No.-37,  
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/5281/N/2026  
(Court Matter)

**SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE**

Branch office: ICICI Bank Ltd., BP-4, Technopolis Building, 4th Floor, Sector V, Salt Lake City, Kolkata West Bengal- 700091  
CIN No: L65190GJ1994PLC021012, [www.icicibank.com](http://www.icicibank.com)

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

| Sr. No. | Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number                                                                                   | Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs) | Name of Branch        |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| 1.      | Pankaj Kumar/ Shakuntala Devi/9, Floor, 2C 344-345 New Ashok Nagar Vasundhara East Delhi Delhi Delhi- 110096/ LBDEL00005692500 | Khata No. 49, Plot No. 82, Touzi No. 5758, Ward No. 10, Thana No. 160, Mauza- Pali, Thana Dihri, Andar Nagar Palika, Anchal Dihri, Dalmia Nagar, District Rohtas, Bihar, Owned By Shakuntala Devi Admeasuring An Area Of 1 (one Katha) 19 (Nineteen Dhur) 6/093 Disami North: Dadho Ahir South: Rasta Bod Hu Jagannaray Tiwari East: Kedar Singh West: Basant Mahato/ Date of Symbolic 17/04/2026 | November 27, 2025 Rs. 36,21,746.00/-         | Delhi/ Dihri/ Gurgaon |

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: April 23, 2026  
Place: Delhi & Gurgaon

Sincerely Authorised Officer  
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
**E-Tender Notice**

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

**E-Tender No.:** JHS-ENGG-C-2026-86      **Approx Cost :** ₹ 57545808.95

**Description of work:** Construction of Loop line towards UP loop line side at JHANSI EI-I cabin under ADEN/LAR.

**Earnest Money:** ₹ 1151000.00 **Date of closing Tender:** 15.05.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

**Date of Completion/period from issue acceptance of letter:** 12 Months.

Tender online can be submitted up to **15:00 hrs on 15.05.2026**. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in)      871/26 (DG)

North central railways      @CPRONCR      www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB**  
**GREATER MOHALI AREA DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY**  
**PUDA Bhawan, Sector 62, SAS Nagar**  
Tender Reference No. . 442-451 dated 22-04-2026

Divisional Engineer (PH-2), GMADA SAS Nagar invites online bids for " Providing and laying of balance storm drainage scheme on 200 feet wide PR-4 road from UT Chandigarh boundary to Jayanti Ki Rao, New Chandigarh area, SAS Nagar including maintenance of 05 years."

Closing date & time: **07-05-2026 at 1:00 PM**  
For details log on to: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

**Note:** Any corrigendum(s) to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only.

RO No PR-Advt. No :- 1324/12/2026-27/10768

**Maharashtra Jeevan Pradhikaran**  
**Division Mangaon.**

**e-Tender Notice No. 07 for 2025-2026 (2nd call)**

Executive Engineer, Maharashtra Jeevan Pradhikaran, Division Mangaon invites e-Tender for the work of **Umate Rural Regional Water Supply Scheme Tq. Alibag Dist. Under JJM Retrofitting of Existing 4.5 MLD WTP RS.29,03,440/-**

The e-Tender details are available on [www.mahatenders.gov.in](http://www.mahatenders.gov.in) from Dated 22/04/2026.

**Date:- 15/04/2026**

**Prashant Pandharpatte (Act.)**  
Executive Engineer MJP  
Dgipr/2026-27/352      Division Mangaon

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**  
**See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Lavneet Yadav S/o Ram Sewak R/o: B-458, Gali No. 6, Prem Vihar, Karawal Nagar, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 18/2026, U/S 3(1) (r) & SC/ST Act & 115(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, PS Karawal Nagar, North East Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Lavneet Yadav** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Lavneet Yadav** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Lavneet Yadav** the said accused of **FIR No. 18/2026, U/S 3(1) (r) & SC/ST Act & 115(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, PS Karawal Nagar, North East Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.05.2026**.

By Order  
Ms. Twinkle Wadhwa  
Additional Sessions Judge-02,  
North-East Distt., Room No.-65,  
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/5217/NE/2026  
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

**See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused 1) Rekha, W/o Vinod, R/o H.No. E-64, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi, 2) Rahul, S/o Pappu, R/o Village Naroli, (Naroli Bypass) Mathura, UP has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 16/2022, U/s 363 IPC & 76 JJ Act, P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said 1) **Rekha**, 2) **Rahul** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said 1) **Rekha**, 2) **Rahul** has absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said 1) **Rekha**, 2) **Rahul** accused of **FIR No. 16/2022, U/s 363 IPC & 76 JJ Act, P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.05.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Pooja Jain  
Additional Session Judge-05, POCOso, North  
DP/5235/ON/2026      Room No. 302, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

**See Section 82 Cr.PC./84 BNSS**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Rajesh Sharma, S/o: Pushp Pal Sharma R/o H.No. 374, Molarband Extn., D-31, Badarpur, New Delhi**, (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 344/2023, Dt. 20.04.2026, U/s: 498A/304B IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Badarpur, New Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Rajesh Sharma**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Rajesh Sharma**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Rajesh Sharma, FIR No.:344/2023, Dt. 20.04.2026, U/s: 498A/304B IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Badarpur, New Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.06.2026**.

By Order  
Sh. Vinod Joshi, Ld.  
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate  
Room No.515, South East District,  
Saket Courts, New Delhi

DP/5238/SE/2026  
(Court Matter)

**SBI STATE BANK OF INDIA,**  
HOMELoan CENTRE, FARIDABAD, NEELAM CHOWK, FIRST FLOOR, NIT, FARIDABAD, HARYANA -121001

**(RULE - 8(1) POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)**

Whereas, the undersigned being the **Authorized Officer of the State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre-Faridabad**, under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets & Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice Dated **23/01/2026** calling upon the Borrowers:- **SH. KRISHAN KUMAR BANGIA S/O LATE SH. RAM CHAND BANGIA**, House No. E-1461, E-Block, Sainik Colony, Sec-49, Faridabad, Haryana-121001 (hereinafter the borrower and guarantors are collectively referred to as the "the Borrowers") to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.63,61,999/- (Rupees Sixty Three Lakh Sixty One Thousand Nine Hundred Ninety Nine Only) + Future Interest at the contractual rate w.e.f. 23/01/2026** within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the amount vide acct. no.30649653370 notice is hereby given to the Borrowers/Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken **Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on this date the **21<sup>st</sup> April 2026**. The Borrower/Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of **State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre - Faridabad** for an amount of **Rs.63,61,999/- (Rupees Sixty Three Lakh Sixty One Thousand Nine Hundred Ninety Nine Only) + Future Interest at the contractual rate w.e.f. 23/01/2026** and incidental expenses, costs, charges, etc. thereon.

**The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.**

**DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY**

All that part and parcel of the property bearing House No.E-1461, Sainik Colony, Sector-49, Faridabad, Haryana.

Place: FARIDABAD      Sd/- Authorised Officer,  
Date: 21/04/2026      State Bank of India, HLC Faridabad

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
**E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE**

Deputy Chief Engineer (Construction), North Central Railway, Agra Cantt for and on behalf of the President of India invites in **TWO PACKET SYSTEM** open tender on prescribed forms online (E-Tendering). Tender offer can be submitted online up to **15.00 hours of 12.05.2026**, on website <http://ireps.gov.in>. The details of the tenders are as under:-

**Tender No.:** E-Tender Notice No. CEN00AGC0626

**Description of work:** Idgah yard remodelling (Provision of two additional lines with platform and connection of AF-BKI doubling in Idgah Yard); Conversion of D-Class station into B- Class station of Bateshwar and Construction of Station Building with platform at Karondhana station in connection with Bhandai Flyover work.

|                                      |                                     |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| <b>Approx Cost:</b> 57.27 Cr. (App.) | <b>Earnest Money :</b> ₹1,14,54,300 |
| <b>Completion Period:</b> 12 Months  | <b>Date of opening:</b> 12.05.2026  |

**Validity: 90 Days** **Note:** For complete details and submission of tender please see Indian Railway's website <http://www.ireps.gov.in>      844/26 FA

North central railways      @CPRONCR      www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
**E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE**

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

| E-Tender No.       | Approx Cost | Earnest Money |
|--------------------|-------------|---------------|
| JHS-ENGG-E-2026-79 | 22758328.50 | 455200.00     |

**Description of work:** VGLJ-KID & LAR-KURJ section:- Heavy repair/Installation of Height Gauges and other ancillary work at different LHS location under jurisdiction of ADEN/MBA.

**Date of closing Tender:** 11.05.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

**Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter :** 08 Months

• Tender online can be submitted up to **15:00 hrs on 11.05.2026**. • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in)      845/26 (ADM)

North central railways      www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in      @CPRONCR

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**  
No.:JHS/W/T/Tender General/81      Date : 17.04.2026

**E-Tender Notice**

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed " Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

**E-Tender No.:** JHS-ENGG-E-2026-81, **Description of work:** Jhansi Division:- Dewatering of accumulated water from various LHS & as directed by site engineer under Sr.DEN/E Jurisdiction for 02 years.

**Approx. Cost:** ₹ 1,30,74,168.19      **Earnest Money :** ₹ 2,61,500.00

**Date of closing Tender :** 11.05.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

**Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter:** 24 Months

Tender online can be submitted up to **15:00 hrs on 11.05.2026** For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website [www.ireps.gov.in](http://www.ireps.gov.in)      849/26 (MG)

North central railways      @CPRONCR      www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**M.P. ROAD DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED**  
(Govt. of M.P. Undertaking)  
45-A, Arera Hills, Bhopal- 462011, Madhya Pradesh  
MPRDC Phone : 0755-2527290/2765205 (EPBX), Fax : 0755-2572643, Website : [www.mprdc.gov.in](http://www.mprdc.gov.in)  
NIT No. 706/MPRDC/Procu/2026

**NOTICE INVITING TENDERS**

Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation Limited (MPRDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works.

| S. No. | Name of Work                                                                                                                                                                                                     | PAC Value (in INR Crore) | Bid Security (EMD) (in INR Lacs) | Cost of Tender Document (i/c GST) (in Rs.) | Period of Completion (including rainy season) |
|--------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 1.     | Upgradation & Reconstruction of Sagar-Damoh Road (SH-63) as 4 lane with paved shoulder in the state of Madhya Pradesh on Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM) (Total Design Length – 73.300 Km)                            | 830.91                   | 831                              | 59,000/-                                   | 24 Months                                     |
| 2.     | Providing and Erection of Single Roller Crash Barrier and road safety work on Matkulipachmarhi road between km. 10 to 24 (SH-41A) (2nd Call)                                                                     | 8.24                     | 8.24                             | 23,600/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 3.     | Providing and Erection of Single Roller Crash Barrier and road safety work on Sardarpur-Rajgarh-Bagh Road (SH-65), Manawar-Mangod Road (SH-38), Rajpur-Palsud-Newali Road (SH-39)                                | 7.84                     | 7.84                             | 23,600/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 4.     | Providing and Erection of Single Roller Crash Barrier and road safety work on Seoni-Katangi-Bonkatta Road, Burhar-Amarkantak Ghat, Rewa-Shahdol, Tilwara-Chargawan-Goteagaon (Gangao nahar)                      | 6.76                     | 6.76                             | 23,600/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 5.     | Renewal and Maintenance work on Badwani-Palsood-Sendhwa Road                                                                                                                                                     | 5.42                     | 5.42                             | 23,600/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 6.     | Consultancy Services for preparation of Detailed Project Report for Construction of Tunnel at Chhuhiya Ghati Section (existing km. 18+550 to 32+800) of Rewa Shahdol Road (SH-57) in the State of Madhya Pradesh | 5.00                     | 5.00                             | 23,600/-                                   | 09 Months                                     |
| 7.     | Repair and Rehabilitation work of Poor and very Poor bridges other than RAMS under Rewa Division (Group-I)                                                                                                       | 3.57                     | 3.57                             | 17,700/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 8.     | Repair and Rehabilitation work of Poor and very Poor bridges other than RAMS under Bhopal, Dhar & Sagar Division (Group-J)                                                                                       | 1.15                     | 1.15                             | 14,750/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 9.     | Reconstruction work of Poor bridges other than RAMS under Jabalpur Division (Group-K)                                                                                                                            | 1.81                     | 1.81                             | 14,750/-                                   | 06 Months                                     |
| 10.    | Long Term Rectification work of Black Spot No. 168 in Dhar Division (2nd Call)                                                                                                                                   | 1.69                     | 1.69                             | 14,750/-                                   | 06 months                                     |

The dates for purchase, submission, etc. are mentioned in the key dates. Tender forms can be purchased online only upto **15:30 hrs. on 14.05.2026 for Sr. No. 02 & 10 and 25.05.2026 for Sr. No. 01 & 03 to 09** from website [www.mptenders.gov.in](http://www.mptenders.gov.in). The bidders have to submit the Technical bid as well as Financial Bid online only. The Addendum/Corrigendum (if any) shall only be published on the website of [www.mptenders.gov.in](http://www.mptenders.gov.in) only. If holiday is declared by Govt. of M.P. on the date of opening, the same will automatically be shifted to subsequent working days.

MPRDC reserves the right to accept/reject any/all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

M.P. Madhyam/125414/2026

**MANAGING DIRECTOR**





## AROUND THE WORLD

- » IIT Kanpur appoints Prof Anil K Lalwani as inaugural dean of medical sciences school
- » IIM Calcutta will host the inaugural event of MBAEx Batch 20 on April 24, marking the beginning of a new journey for the incoming cohort
- » Mahindra University and Temple University forge global academic alliance and launch accelerated dual degree programmes
- » IIM Kashipur commenced the Executive PG Diploma in Hospital Management programme



## BUZZER ROUND

**Q) WHICH CITY IN THE WORLD HAS THE MOST MICHELIN STAR RESTAURANTS?**

Send us your replies to [careersmp22@gmail.com](mailto:careersmp22@gmail.com). We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our April 16 edition question:  
**Hong Kong**

Correct answers were sent by:  
**Swarnashree Ghosh, Debdeep Raha, Kirti Mandal**



## NEWS &amp; VIEWS

IIT Madras will host a Technology Summit in Delhi on May 5. With the theme "From IITM. For Bharat. Building Together," the summit is envisioned as a high-impact platform to strengthen industry-academia-government collaboration.

NIT Rourkela Research team has developed a novel bio-ink that can be used in 3D bioprinting and tissue engineering. Bio-inks are materials used in 3D bioprinting to fabricate tissue-like structures.

# WHY SOUTH KOREA IS A TOP CHOICE FOR INDIAN STUDENTS

*Strategic partnership boost and rising academic appeal make South Korea a top study destination for Indians*

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

South Korean President Lee Jae-myung met Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi to strengthen the India-South Korea special strategic partnership. The meeting led to the launch of an India-Korea digital bridge, aimed at expanding collaboration in artificial intelligence, semiconductors and information technology. Both countries also signed MoUs in key sectors such as shipbuilding, sustainability, steel and ports, reinforcing economic and technological cooperation.

Now, South Korea is increasingly emerging as a preferred destination for Indian students. The number of Indian students in South Korea has risen sharply in recent years, reflecting the country's growing appeal as a study destination. Estimates suggest that around 1,500 to over 3,500 Indian students were enrolled during the 2023-24 academic year. Recent data also shows that this number has doubled between 2020 and 2024, highlighting a steady increase in interest towards South Korean universities among Indian students. Known for its vibrant culture, safety, and strong academic ecosystem, South Korea houses six universities ranked among the world's top 100, with several attracting a growing number of Indian applicants. We list some of the universities popular among Indian students.

## KOREA ADVANCED INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Located in Daejeon, KAIST ranks 53rd globally and is a leading research university. With 11% international students, it offers most of its courses in English, making it highly accessible to foreign students. Known for excellence in engineering, natural sciences and computer science,



KAIST also benefits from its scenic surroundings, including forests, lakes and hiking trails that provide a balanced student life.

## KYUNG HEE UNIVERSITY

Kyung Hee University in Seoul is widely regarded as one of the most visually stunning campuses in South Korea. Ranked 328th globally, it has 10% international students and offers programmes in hospitality, nursing and modern languages. The campus is equipped with museums, dining facilities, dormitories, a bank and a gym, providing a self-sufficient environment for students.

## SOGANG UNIVERSITY

Sogang University, located in Seoul, is known for its strong emphasis on Korean language learning and cultural integration. With 17% international students, it offers programmes in modern languages, economics and

humanities. Its Korean Language Education Center is among the best in the country, focusing heavily on speaking skills and cultural activities to enhance learning.

## SUNGKYUNKWAN UNIVERSITY

One of Korea's oldest universities, Sungkyunkwan University combines historical legacy with modern industry connections. Ranked 123rd globally, it has 14% international students and offers courses in materials science, social sciences and more.

## YONSEI UNIVERSITY

Located in Seoul, Yonsei University offers an engaging campus experience with a strong focus on extracurricular involvement. With 12% international undergraduate students and top programs in business, engineering and social sciences, the university

ranks 56th globally. Students benefit from a lively campus culture that includes clubs, festivals and sports, along with freshman dorm initiatives that encourage social interaction and exploration of city life.

## KOREA UNIVERSITY

Also based in Seoul, Korea University stands out for its comprehensive student support services. With 8% international undergraduates and a QS ranking of 67, it offers programmes in marketing, modern languages and social sciences. The university provides mental health counselling in English, academic mentoring, and accessibility support, ensuring a smooth transition for both degree-seeking and exchange students.

## CHONNAM NATIONAL UNIVERSITY

Situated in Gwangju, Chonnam

## KOREAN LOVE

**S**OUTH KOREA offers a compelling mix of affordability, quality education and global exposure. Tuition fees are relatively lower compared to many Western countries, while a wide range of programmes are taught in English, thus making it easy for Indian students. The country is also known for its safety, stable governance and low crime rates. Beyond academics, students can enjoy Korea's rich culinary scene as well as its globally popular pop culture. The rise of K-pop and K-dramas collectively adds to the country's appeal as an exciting and dynamic place to study and live.

National University is known for its affordability. With lower tuition fees and a reduced cost of living compared to Seoul, it is an attractive choice for budget-conscious students. Ranked between 851-900 globally, the university specialises in agriculture, life sciences and natural sciences. Its location offers a mix of scenic landscapes, historic sites and a rich culinary tradition.

## SEOUL NATIONAL UNIVERSITY

Seoul National University, often regarded as the "Harvard of South Korea," ranks 31st globally and attracts top talent from across the world. With 15% international students, it is known for excellence in engineering, life sciences and computer science. Nearly all faculty members hold doctoral degrees from leading global institutions, and graduates often go on to hold prominent positions, making it a strong addition to any academic profile.

## Gender gap in deep tech widens as 43% firms struggle to hire women in AI & ML

*Career advancement for women into mid-level roles often takes longer*

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**W**omen remain underrepresented in India's deep tech sector, with representation gaps at entry-level and persisting through senior roles, revealed a recent survey by Indeed's latest Hiring Tracker (IHT). The survey, which focuses on specialised fields such as AI/ML, Data Science, and Cybersecurity, points to a combination of hiring trends, pay perceptions, and progression timelines as key factors shaping the workforce.

The data indicate that female representation remains limited from the start of the career pipeline. Nearly half of employers surveyed (43%) report that women constitute only 0-10% of their entry-level deep tech hires. Furthermore, no surveyed organisation reported female representation exceeding 50% at any level of seniority.

Active job-seeking among women in this sector has remained stable, with 43% reporting active applications in Q4, compared to 42% in Q3, suggesting that the representation gap is not due to a lack of activity among female professionals but rather structural entry barriers.

The report highlights a divergence in how pay and growth are experienced



within organisations. 38% of employers report that women take longer to progress to mid-level roles compared to their male counterparts. Approximately 32% of employees believe colleagues of the opposite gender earn more for similar work. This includes 34% of women who believe men earn more, and 31% of men who believe women earn more. While 67% of employers report no gender pay gap at senior levels, 27% of employees perceive that the gap actually widens with seniority.

The report also notes differences in how candidates approach job offers. Male candidates are more likely to negotiate salaries, which may impact long-term pay trajectories. Additionally, women showed greater openness to roles with lower incremental increases, with 23% willing to accept salary hikes of 10% or less.

Approximately 32% of employees believe colleagues of the opposite gender earn more for similar work

## SCHOLARSHIP

## India opens AYUSH scholarships for foreign students

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**I**ndia has opened applications for the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) AYUSH Scholarship Scheme 2026-27, inviting foreign nationals to pursue studies in traditional systems such as Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy. Offered on behalf of the Ministry of AYUSH, the programme falls under the International Fellowship initiative and aims to promote India's heritage of holistic healthcare globally. The last date to apply is May 15, 2026.

## COURSES OFFERED

- » BAMS, BSMS, BUMS, BHMS (5.5 years with internship)
- » BSc Yoga, BA Yoga Shastra (3 years)
- » MD in Ayurveda, Siddha, Unani, Homoeopathy (3 years)
- » MSc Yoga (2 years)
- » PhD in Ayurveda, Unani (3 years)

## Eligibility criteria

- » Must be a foreign national
- » Minimum age: 18 years
- » UG: 12 years schooling (Science for medical streams)
- » PG: Relevant recognised degree
- » PhD: Recognised postgraduate qualification
- » Documents must be submitted with English translations
- » Apply before May 15, 2026

## Scholarship benefits

- » Financial assistance
- » Admission to top AYUSH institutions
- » Airfare support (arrival & return)
- » Academic and cultural exposure

## BLACKBOARD

**G**iven the scorching heat and heatwave across Delhi and NCR, the Directorate of Education (National Capital Territory of Delhi) issued guidelines to all government-aided and private unaided recognised schools. The directive mentions that outdoor assemblies should be conducted in indoor areas with minimal duration. No open-air classes are to be conducted. Schools are also required to implement a "Water Bell" system, whereby a bell is rung at regular intervals (every 45-60 minutes) reminding students to drink water to prevent dehydration.

**B**anaras Hindu University has been pledged a USD 60,000 donation to establish scholarships and research assistance for students of the Department of Biochemistry, Institute of Science. The varsity has signed a MoU with the BHU America Foundation (BHUAFA) and distinguished scientists Dr Nirbhay Kumar and Dr Geetha Bansal for this purpose. As part of the MoU, the first tranche of Rs 25 lakh will support five merit-cum-means scholarships of Rs 25,000 per year for MSc Biochemistry second-year students, beginning in 2026.

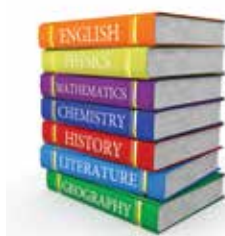
**I**IM Kozhikode is offering Chief Product & AI-Driven Strategy Officer (CPAIO) Programme. This one-of-a-kind programme is designed to equip product leaders with the strategic foresight, innovation mindset, and AI-driven capabilities to join the league of the top 1% of product growth leaders. Participants will learn how to drive vision-led strategies and innovation, unlock growth with design and 10X thinking, scale digital platforms and ecosystems, harness AI tools and product analytics, lead teams and embed product-led culture.

## NHRC QUESTIONS SCHOOLS OVER COSTLY PRIVATE TEXTBOOKS

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**T**he National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) on Wednesday issued notices to the Union Ministry of Education, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), and Chief Secretaries of all states and Union Territories over allegations that private schools are prescribing expensive textbooks from private publishers in violation of statutory norms.

A Bench led by NHRC Member Priyank Kanoongo took cognisance of a complaint claiming that several schools, including CBSE-affiliated institutions, continue to mandate privately



published books instead of those recommended by NCERT or SCERTs.

The complaint states this practice places an undue financial burden on families, as private books are far costlier than subsidised NCERT texts. It also alleges the trend undermines the goals of the National Education Policy 2020 and violates Section 29 of the Right to Education Act, 2009.

## BEYOND CAMPUS

The IIT Kharagpur bid a heartfelt farewell to its graduating batch through Alvida 2026, a memorable evening hosted by the Office of Alumni Affairs. The event brought together students, faculty, and alumni. The evening was further graced by the presence of Prof Suman Chakraborty, Director IIT Kharagpur; Prof Anandaroop Bhattacharya, Dean, International Relations; Prof Siddhartha Mukhopadhyay, Dean, Alumni Affairs and others.



## Trending

## COURSES

## OUTCOME-ORIENTED MANAGEMENT PROGRAMME FOR WORKING PROFESSIONALS FROM IIM MUMBAI

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**I**IM Mumbai has entered into a partnership with Masai to launch new programmes for working professionals. For many professionals, access to quality management education remains constrained by cost, format, and limited flexibility. Through this collaboration, the institutes seek to address that gap by

introducing programmes that are both accessible and closely aligned with industry requirements.

Spanning management, wealth management, and the performing arts, the programmes will be delivered through weekend, on-campus sessions, allowing participants to continue working while they study. Graduates will receive IIM Mumbai alumni status along with certification. The programmes include:

## POSTGRADUATE PROGRAMME IN MANAGEMENT (MBA-PGPM)

A TWO-YEAR programme for professionals aiming to move into senior management roles. Delivered in a weekend format, it covers core business functions including finance, marketing, operations, and strategy, with a focus on applied learning. It's open to candidates with at least two years of work experience.

## POSTGRADUATE EXECUTIVE PROGRAMME IN CREATIVE LEADERSHIP - ARTPRENEUR (PGPCL-A)

THIS ONE-YEAR weekend programme is designed for performing artists looking to build sustainable, independent careers. It integrates business fundamentals with creative practice, with a focus on entrepreneurship, personal branding, and project development. It's open to graduates with at least 50 percent marks or equivalent.